



'ILLEGAL DETENTION'

Assam Police hold CJP volunteers for hours

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Bank unions defer 3-day strike after talks with IBA

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GUIDANCE DISENGAGEMENT

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EURASIAN OPPORTUNITIES

Kashmir as India's gateway

Reconnecting the Valley's routes could unlock its potential: Mehbooba

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CHESS OLYMPIAD

Indian men win silver, women claim bronze

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INSIDE



Iran firm on plan for reopening Hormuz Strait

WASHINGTON/TEHRAN Iran stood firm on Sunday on its conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz, despite U.S. President Donald Trump's rejection of the proposal. "We will not back down" from the conditions, Iran's Foreign Minister said. » PAGE 14

Wangchuk seeks more relief for Leh riot victims

SRINAGAR Activist Sonam Wangchuk on Sunday demanded that the findings of the judicial inquiry into the September 2026 violence in Leh be made public. Questioning the compensation of ₹15 lakh for the families of victims, he said it was inadequate. » PAGE 4

Dozens killed in air raids by Saudi fighters: Houthis

SANAA Airstrikes by Saudi Arabia on Taiz in southwest Yemen caused dozens of casualties in an area controlled by the Houthis, the group said on Sunday, as fighting escalated further after a truce broke down months ago. » PAGE 14

CMRL 'scam' case: 'ED report not enough for FIR'

KOZHIKODE Kerala Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Sunday said an FIR cannot be registered against Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan and others merely on the basis of a ED proposal in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case. » PAGE 3

EC failed to undo 'disenfranchisement': Cong.

Poll body's measures amount to an admission that SIR exercise has been a 'disaster', says party

What is the value of promising second round of visits which likely will not happen, asks Ramesh

Targeted removal of marginalised voters meant to benefit the BJP, alleges party spokesperson

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after the Election Commission announced multiple steps to address the concerns raised about the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Congress on Sunday termed it a "desperate attempt at damage control" that "hides all and reveals nothing".

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said the proposed measures amounted to an admission that the exercise had been a "disaster", warning that the "piecemeal" steps for deleted or at-risk voters would do little to mitigate what he called "mass disenfranchisement".

He questioned several of the assurances given by the EC, including its proposal to review the ECINet software and plan for

booth-level officers to visit the electors who received notices instead of requiring them to attend public hearings. "We know that in practice these visits were sparse and sporadic. What is the value of promising a second round of visits which likely will not happen? The logic of repeating a process done poorly once must be examined," he said.

Questioning the rationale of the entire SIR process, which he described as a "colossal waste" of resources, Mr. Ramesh said that nearly 14 crore voters whose names were deleted across the three phases from the rolls were now being asked to apply afresh for inclusion. The targeted removal of marginalised voters was meant to benefit the BJP, he said.

The Congress leader said the EC had failed to address concerns about ECINet, which he claimed



Congress workers hold a protest rally in Kolkata on Saturday demanding suspension of the SIR. AP

had been used to delete eligible voters and override electoral registration officers. The EC's proposal to review the software's compliance with existing laws was an admission that its legality was in question,

Mr. Ramesh said. He asked whether the issues flagged in Goa had occurred elsewhere, including in West Bengal. He also questioned the lack of transparency over ECINet's operation and the use of artificial in-

telligence in electoral roll preparation.

Form 6 changes Mr. Ramesh further alleged that an illegal change to Form 6 had not been adequately explained. He said

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJ against EC

NEW DELHI Over 2,000 citizens across the country have signed an open letter to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, urging him to initiate suo motu proceedings against the conduct of the Election Commission regarding the SIR and the deployment of the ECINet software. The letter seeks the immediate stay and rescission of SIR in all States and Union Territories pending an independent judicial review of its legality and procedural integrity. » PAGE 5

The EC had relied on a Supreme Court judgment of May 27, permitting the addition of a new declaration in Form 6, to defend the change. However, he argued that, in July, the modification had been made to

the online Form 6 for all voters, and not only for those covered under the SIR exercise.

"The same judgment also states that the ECI on its own cannot depart from the statutory procedure without a rational basis," he said.

Mr. Ramesh also contended that the non-SIR Form 6 route being offered to voters was misleading because the Special Summary Revision (SSR) had remained frozen since 2024, and no non-SIR voter roll was being published through which voters could have their names added.

He further argued that the Commission's assurances on meeting procedures and compliance effectively acknowledged that established norms had not been followed, describing the situation as deeply troubling for a constitutional authority.

Joy unbound



Ecstatic: Ancy Sojan is over the moon after winning the silver medal in the women's long jump at the Asian Games on Sunday. Sarvesh Kushare (high jump), Anahat Singh, and Abhay Singh (squash) too won silver medals on Sunday. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT: PAGE 13)

5 'terrorists' held near U.K. base used by U.S. Air Force

Agence France-Presse
FAIRFORD

British counter-terrorism forces were probing "a major incident" near a base used by the U.S. Air Force in its war against Iran after arresting five men on suspicion of "preparing a terrorist act", the police said on Sunday.

U.S. President Donald Trump said the suspects were aiming to do significant damage to the base. "They were looking to do big damage to our fort, and working with the British worked out great," he said.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 14



Protesters block the National Highway near LPU campus in Punjab on Sunday. PTI

Protests erupt over Punjab 'campus rape'

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

Allegations that a student was raped on the campus of Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Punjab sparked an agitation that led to protesters, mainly students, blocking National Highway-44 near Phagwara on Sunday.

The stir, which took place hours after the protesters went on a rampage and vandalised university property, disrupted traffic and led to clashes with the police.

The police registered a first information report (FIR) containing rape charges against unknown persons, and a special investigation team has been constituted to probe the matter. The students have alleged that a female hosteller had been raped by a plumber three days ago and claimed that no action had been taken in the matter so far. LPU, a private institute, has denied the allegations.

Clash with police Despite the FIR and assurances from LPU Vice Chancellor Jaspal Singh Sandhu, protesters held their ground through Sunday, demanding that the university's founder-chancellor and Rajya Sabha MP,

Ashok Mittal, personally come to the protest site to give them his assurance of action in the case. In April, Mr. Mittal was one of seven Rajya Sabha MPs who quit the State's ruling Aam Aadmi Party to join the BJP.

A clash broke out between the police and students on Sunday evening, when protesters allegedly threw some bottles and stones at the police. Police responded with baton-charge. Some police vehicles were then set on fire. Senior Superintendent of Police (Jalandhar) Harvinder Singh Virk told journalists that a few police personnel had sustained injuries and police vehicles had been damaged.

Varsity denies charges In a statement, LPU said the allegation of rape on campus was untrue. LPU registrar Monica Gulati said that rumours circulating on social media were false and misleading, and were circulated by mischievous sources. The university also released a video statement featuring three female students from room no. 504 of the GH-3 hostel, in which they claimed that no such incident had taken place, and said they had been staying there for the past two months.

75-year-old endures 12 hours in raging river amid lurking crocodiles

Woman from Jajpur was dragged for 25 km by the swollen Brahmani river in Odisha after falling into it; rescued in neighbouring district on Sunday

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

For more than 12 hours in pitch darkness, a 75-year-old woman in Odisha clung to life as the raging Brahmani river carried her through swollen floodwaters for nearly 25 km. .

With crocodiles lurking in the turbulent waters and the river showing no mercy, every passing minute brought Keshi Dalai closer to death. Yet, against all odds, she survived the ordeal and was rescued alive on Sunday morning. Ms. Dalai, a resident of Kalakhanda, a riverside village in Jajpur district,



Keshi Dalai after her rescue in Kendrapara of Odisha on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

had gone to the riverbank to relieve herself late on Saturday evening while her family was asleep. She was swept away by the river, which was in spate following heavy rain, after she lost her balance.

The stretch of the Brahmani where she fell in is known for its crocodiles. Residents have erected

barricades in the water at several places for protection. More than 20 people have been dragged into the river by the crocodiles over the past five years. Against this backdrop, Ms. Dalai's survival through the dead of night is being hailed as nothing short of a miracle.

Throughout the night, Ms. Dalai managed to remain afloat. On Sunday morning, she was spotted waving for help and was rescued by a group of youth at Balipatna village in Kendrapara district – at a distance of 25 km by river course and 45 km by road from her village. "In the morning, we could not find her. As the search continued, a call from the

Pattamundai police in Kendrapara brought us immense relief," said Aranya Dalai, Ms. Dalai's son-in-law.

"We saw someone struggling in the swollen Brahmani. Her hands would emerge from the water intermittently before she was swept further downstream. That was enough for us to realise that she was still alive. We immediately rushed in a country boat to rescue her," said Abhijit Sahoo, one of the rescuers.

"When we pulled her out, she had swallowed a considerable amount of water and her body had turned pale. Local village women immediately

attended to her, and within half an hour, she was able to speak. She was subsequently taken to a hospital and handed over to the police," Mr. Sahoo said.

Other stories of survival In multiple flooding incidents this year in Odisha, several astonishing stories of survival have emerged. In Bhadrak district, a farmer survived by clinging to a palm tree for five days when floodwaters suddenly inundated his farmland. He was rescued after floodwaters subsided. In another incident, three youths were swept away by strong currents while filming

video reels in Balasore district. They managed to grab a tree and held on until they were rescued.

The control room of Special Relief Commissioner under the Odisha Revenue and Disaster Management Department has placed the official death toll from floods and rain at seven. However, disaster experts allege that the government is downplaying casualties to project a lower toll.

Meanwhile, Odisha is bracing for another round of flooding in the Mahanadi, Baitarani and Brahmani river systems. The State administration, however, said that the magnitude of the flooding will be minor.

INBRIEF



56 dead, flood-like situation as heavy rain wreaks havoc in U.P.

Fifty-six people were killed in thunderstorms and rain-related incidents in Uttar Pradesh since Friday, with at least eight districts facing a flood-like situation after an intense three-day wet spell, officials said on Sunday. The State received 45.1 mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending Sunday, against the normal 1.8 mm. The highest number of deaths during the 60-hour period was reported from Sitapur, followed by Lakhimpur Kheri, Bahraich, Balrampur, Ayodhya and Gorakhpur. The officials said 1,021 houses were damaged. People from flood-affected areas have been shifted to flood relief centres, they added.

Days after joining Waris Punjab De, ex-ED officer quits party

Just five days after joining the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De, former Enforcement Directorate (ED) Deputy Director Niranjan Singh resigned from the Amritpal Singh-led party on Sunday, citing differences on various issues. Mr. Niranjn had joined the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De on September 23 in the presence of party leaders Manpreet Singh Ayali and Tarsem Singh. In a Facebook post on Sunday, Mr. Niranjn announced his decision to disassociate from the party. He did not elaborate on the specific issues that led to his resignation. PTI

T.N. head constable risks life to nab gutkha smugglers from Rajasthan

Wilson Thomas
COIMBATORE

In a high-octane chase, a Coimbatore policeman on Sunday clung onto an SUV for over 40 km as three persons from Rajasthan attempted to escape with banned tobacco products.

M. Velmurugan, 38, a head constable attached to the Kovilpalayam police station, held onto the roof rails of the SUV, which had about 230 kg of gutkha.

According to senior police officers, information on the smuggling from Benga-



Policeman M. Velmurugan holding onto the roof rails of the SUV. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

luru to Coimbatore was received and a team identified the white SUV at Vellanaipatti. They then

SPOTLIGHT

Jacob Koshy

Indian Standard Time (IST) is created at the CSIR-National Physical Laboratory (NPL) in a room the size of an office cubicle on a sprawling Delhi campus. This, not in the Einsteinian way of space and gravity doing mysterious things, nor in the pejorative way about Indian time being stretchable. Time here emerges as a consensus of a parliament of clocks.

On August 27, the Department of Consumer Affairs notified the Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026, which make IST the only permissible time reference in the country for legal, administrative, commercial and official purposes, require that it be drawn from an authorised Indian source, and come into force in the last week of February 2027.

It is easy to forget that a second does not exist. Not in the existentialist, what-really-is-time sense, but in the same way that a decibel is just a ratio of perceived sound to the quietest imaginable quiet. The ‘second’, that way, is a mathematical derivative and a unit of repetition.

Take anything that repeats regularly, divide its duration into equal parts, and those parts become ‘units’. For millennia that thing was the Earth:

86,400 seconds made a day. Nothing could seem more regular, until it emerged that it was not. The Moon’s pull, ocean currents, the breathing atmosphere and the churn of magma deep inside the planet all, incrementally, upset its rotation.

Atoms are steadier. If elements were musical genres, the soft silvery-golden caesium would be punk; it melts at room temperature and reacts violently with water. In a vacuum, however, it is unusually well behaved. Its atoms possess a switch between two internal states, triggered by radiation, at one exact frequency. In 1967, the General Conference on Weights and Measures ordained that a second was 9,192,631,770 cycles of that radiation.

An atomic clock does not count seconds by watching anything move. NPL’s are beige boxes stacked on two grey racks, and inside each is a sealed tube under vacuum. The clock needs a signal at roughly the right frequency, and something to tell it when that signal is exactly right. The signal comes from an ordinary quartz oscillator, of the sort in a ₹2,000 watch, whose hum the electronics multiply up into microwaves. The second is caesium. Atoms boil in a small oven and fly the length of the tube through those microwaves; if the frequency is exactly

Haldwani row: Cong. to take ‘abuse of SC, ST rights’ to national stage

Upping ante against BJP govts. in Centre, Uttarakhand over Aug. 11 ‘ritual’ following Kharge’s rally, party forum to hold meeting in Delhi tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Stepping up its campaign against the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) governments at the Centre and in Uttarakhand, the Congress’s SC/ST Parliamentarians Forum on Sunday announced a ‘Dalit-Adivasi Self-Respect Meeting’ in Delhi on Tuesday over the ‘shuddhikaran puja’ (purification ritual) held in Haldwani on August 11, two days after a rally at the venue addressed by party president Mallikarjun Kharge. The platform will be used to highlight violations of the laws protecting Dalits and Adivasis from discrimination and violence across the country, the forum added.

The incident, which Mr. Kharge raised in the Rajya Sabha during the Monsoon Session of Parliament, drew widespread criticism over caste-based discrimination. On September 8, nearly a month after the ‘ritual’, the Nainital police registered an FIR against



Congress members protesting in Dehradun last month demanding the arrest of all those involved in the ‘purification ritual’. ANI

‘unknown persons’.

Addressing a press conference in Delhi on Sunday, Congress MP Mallu Ravi said the incident reflected the mindset of the Uttarakhand and Union governments. He criticised the State dispensation’s “initial refusal” to register an FIR, saying the case was lodged only after protests from the Opposition party. “Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah and Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami have not yet condemned the incident,” Mr. Ravi said.

Congress leader Manoj Kumar accused the Modi government of being “anti-Dalit” and “anti-tribal” and claimed that atrocities against Dalits and tribals had increased under Mr. Modi. He appealed to Dalit and tribal MLAs across the country to participate in the meeting.

Mr. Kumar said they will discuss incidents of discrimination and violence covered under the Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955 and the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989.

Students clash with right-wing group on film institute campus

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Violence erupted in the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) campus in Kolkata on Sunday as students clashed with members of a right-wing consumer welfare organisation, who were holding a meeting inside the institute’s auditorium.

The meeting of the Akhil Bharatiya Grahak Panchayat (ABGP) started at 10

a.m. A section of students objected to the entry of outsiders and questioned why the institute allowed a private organisation to hold a meeting on campus.

The students purportedly put up posters near the auditorium as a mark of protest, following which a heated exchange took place between them and members of the ABGP. Soon, violence broke out, and each group accused the other of attacking its members.

Ex-Minister, BSP leader, others join Congress in U.P. ahead of State poll

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

A former Uttar Pradesh Minister and a 2024 Lok Sabha candidate from the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) were among dozens of leaders who joined the Congress at the State unit office in Lucknow on Sunday. Welcoming them into the party fold, State Congress president Ajay Rai said their entry signals the party’s growing support and momentum in the run-up to the 2027 Assembly election.

Izhar-ul-Haq, a former close aide of BSP chief Mayawati who served as a Minister after she was sworn in as Chief Minister in 1995, and Naeem Ahmed, a former BSP leader who contested the 2024 general election on a BSP ticket were among the leaders who joined the Congress. “Former Minister Izhar-ul-Haq and Naeem Ahmed have strong social base in their respective regions, a clear message is that winds of change are now clearly blowing in Uttar Pradesh,” said Mr. Rai.

The development comes three days after former MP Amir Alam



U.P. Cong. chief Ajay Rai (left) welcoming the leaders to the party. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Khan, and his son and former MLA Nawazish Alam Khan joined the Congress, along with leaders of All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen, Azad Samaj Party, Aam Aadmi Party and Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). Mr. Amir Alam represented Kairana Lok Sabha seat for the RLD and was a three-time MLA.

“Since Rahul Gandhi’s Bharat Jodo Yatra, people across the country, the Muslim community in particular, have placed faith in the Congress party. People believe only the Congress can protect the plural, democratic fabric of the country against the authoritarian tendencies of the BJP,” said party national secretary Shah Nawaz Alam.

Apni Party: hold NC accountable for ‘demographic changes’ in J&K

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

J&K Apni Party president Syed Mohammad Altaf Bukhari on Sunday claimed that outsiders were buying land in Kashmir, and the ruling National Conference (NC) must be held accountable if any demographic change occurred in Jammu and Kashmir.

“It is the government’s responsibility to prevent any attempt to change demography. Who allowed Mumbai-based Chawla sahib to purchase land for a

hotel in Syedpora and a Delhi-based company to acquire 150 kanals in Chatterhama Hazratbal, despite the fact that such activities are not permissible under the existing domicile laws of Jammu and Kashmir?” Mr. Bukhari said at a public speech in Srinagar.

Mr. Bukhari, who quit the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) to float his own party after the abrogation of J&K’s special status in 2019, said the NC had sought votes on the planks of restoration of Articles 370 and 35A, and

Chautala: INLD only credible Oppn. to BJP in Haryana

The Hindu Bureau
NUH

Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) chief Abhay Singh Chautala on Sunday blamed former Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda for the Bharatiya Janata Party’s (BJP) return to power in Haryana in the 2024 Assembly poll and trained his guns on the Janayak Janta Party. He termed it rge “B-team” of the BJP and the Congress and positioned his party as the only credible opposition to the ruling party.

Addressing the party’s ‘Samman Diwas’ rally in Nuh to mark the 113th birth anniversary of the late former Deputy Prime Minister Chaudhary Devi Lal, Mr. Chautala said the INLD would work to “remove the BJP from power and keep the Congress away from power” in the State.

Bid to reconnect

The choice of Nuh as the venue is politically significant for the INLD, which is attempting to reconnect with a region where it once had an organisational and electoral base. The Congress won all three Assembly seats in Nuh district in the 2024 election.



Serious claim: The BJP has accused the Congress govt. of lacking commitment to help drought-hit farmers in the State. ARUN KULKARNI

BJP, JD(S) opt out of Karnataka delegation on drought relief

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Opposition Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Janata Dal (Secular) have refused to be part of the proposed all-party delegation planned by the Karnataka government to meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi to seek Central assistance for drought relief.

On Sunday, Union Minister and JD(S) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy and Leader of the Opposition in the Legislative Assembly R. Ashok said that they would not be part of the proposed delegation.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar is leaving for Delhi on Monday to take part in the Congress Working Committee meeting scheduled for Tuesday.

Mr. Kumaraswamy said the State representatives could go on their own, and that there was no need for an all-party delegation.

Mr. Shivakumar, at the end of the four-day special session convened to discuss the drought, farm distress, and the Kasturirangan Committee report, announced that an all-par-

Karnataka is seeking a meeting between PM and an all-party delegation regarding drought relief: CM

ty delegation would be taken to Mr. Modi to seek Central assistance in drought mitigation efforts.

‘Unnecessary expense’
“What will you do by taking an all-party delegation to the Centre? It will add to the expenditure of the exchequer. Spending on flights and stay in star-category hotels is an unnecessary expenditure. Could someone not go and speak to the Centre?” the Union Minister told presspersons on Sunday. Stating he would not say that the State has gone bankrupt, he said, “It is you who has been sitting on an empty treasury.”

Meanwhile, Mr. Ashok said they would not go to the Centre to seek funds for drought relief.

“We are ready to meet the Union Minister over the Kasturirangan report,” he added.

ED report alone can’t be basis for FIR in CMRL case: Minister

The agency has sought FIR against Pinarayi, daughter, and son-in-law; Home Minister says Kerala govt. decided to first conduct a preliminary inquiry as there was lack of clarity on certain aspects

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Keralam Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Sunday said that an FIR cannot be lodged against Leader of the Opposition and Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, and her husband and CPI(M) State secretariat member P.A. Mohamed Riyas merely on the basis of a proposal from the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

The agency has alleged that the CMRL made fraudulent payments of ₹2.78 crore to Ms. Veena’s now-



State’s stand: Inquiry was ordered based on Advocate-General’s advice in the CMRL pay-off case, said Ramesh Chennithala. H. VIBHU

defunct company, Exalogic Solutions, under the guise of “IT consultancy services”.

The ED had sought registration of a case based on “evidence” gathered during its probe and searches conducted under

the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

Mr. Chennithala told presspersons that the State government recently ordered a preliminary inquiry into the issue based on the legal advice it received. “The government is not

opposed to registering an FIR in the case. But we decided to first conduct a preliminary inquiry based on the Advocate-General’s advice as there was a lack of clarity on certain things,” he said.

High Court directive

He said that the government had placed its stand in the Kerala High Court.

The High Court, on Saturday, directed the ED to submit the records it had provided to the Kerala Police while recommending registration of a case against Mr. Vijayan and his family. The court will hear the matter next on September 29. (With inputs from PTI)

Keralam CM calls for CEC’s resignation

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Keralam Chief Minister V. D. Satheesan on Sunday joined the growing chorus of political leaders demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

In a statement, Mr. Satheesan said that former Chief Secretary Jiji Thomson’s revelation that Mr. Kumar had sought to persuade him to join the BJP and contest on the party ticket from the Pathanamthitta Lok Sabha consti-

tuency in 2019 has raised worrying questions about the Election Commission’s political even-handedness and neutrality.

“Mr. Kumar has operated recurrently as the BJP’s agent, compromising the EC’s public credibility. He has lost the moral and constitutional right to continue in office and should step down immediately,” Mr. Satheesan said.

‘Risk to democracy’

Mr. Satheesan alleged that Mr. Kumar had tethered the EC to the BJP’s post and made the constitutional

election watchdog an appendage of the Sangh Parishad. “His continuation in the EC would further imperil India’s already flailing democracy,” he said.

Mr. Satheesan’s statement seemed to assume political and constitutional significance against the backdrop of allegations Mr. Kumar had overruled two Election Commissioners to exclude lakhs of people, chiefly those hailing from minority communities and marginalised sections of society, from the electoral rolls to stack the decks in favour of the BJP in As-

sembly and Lok Sabha elections.

Mr. Thomson told *The Hindu* on Sunday that Mr. Kumar had made a friendly suggestion, not an offer, when sharing a flight to New Delhi.

However, the ruling United Democratic Front (UDF) and the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Opposition touted Mr. Thomson’s statement as more definitive proof of Mr. Kumar “subverting the EC to rig the electoral system in favour of the pro-corporate and Hindu nationalist dispensation at the Centre”.

INBRIEF



CJP opens chapter in Keralam; receives 20,000 registrations

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) is keen to expand its base in Keralam even as it stepped up campaign for resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar for alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision. The CJP has received about 20,000 registrations, the highest from any State, said CJP national media lead Vijay Reddy Mallangi. At a meet attended by about 150 supporters in Kochi, he questioned the BJP for defending the CEC. People from different age groups attended the meet, said to be the CJP’s first official one in the State.

Three suspects detained in A.P. over woman’s murder

Nearly 10 days after a woman’s body parts were found in a canal in Andhra Pradesh’s NTR district, the police have taken three suspects into custody. The police recovered the dismembered body from the VTPS cooling canal in Ibrahimpatnam on September 18. After going through ‘woman missing’ cases in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, the police identified the victim as 28-year-old Kalyani Durga from Mangalagiri. The police say the victim was in a relationship with a mutton shop owner and had quarrelled with him a day before she was killed.

KSRTC to run more inter-State services for festival season

The Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) has announced special inter-State services to accommodate the travel rush associated with Mahanavami, Vijayadashami and Diwali celebrations. From October 14 to November 14, additional buses will operate between cities such as Bengaluru, Mysuru and Chennai, and various locations in Keralam. Online reservation facilities have already been launched, allowing passengers to book tickets in advance without hassle.

Keralam Minister defends using luxury car as official vehicle

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Keralam Minister for Local Self-Governments and Indian Union Muslim League leader K.M. Shaji has again defended his use of a luxury car with a State government registration plate, accusing news media of lapping up a controversy created by the “cyber wing” of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)].

Mr. Shaji told presspersons on Sunday that his photo being circulated on social media, which showed him leaning on the car, was created by using artificial intelligence. He

said a Minister need not use only a government vehicle. The rule says that it should have a tricolour.

“The vehicle being used by a Minister is the Minister’s vehicle, and it can be a private one... The only issue is that we should not grant any favours in return,” Mr. Shaji said, adding that the rules would have to be “changed” if someone wanted to put him in the dock.

Mr. Shaji had come under criticism for affixing the State government registration plate, Keralam State 13, reserved for the official vehicles of Ministers, on a privately owned luxury vehicle.

Hanging home



Rare sight: A baya weaver (*Ploceus philippinus*) enters its nest on a palm tree in Palakkad, Keralam. Once commonly seen here, the bird and its distinctive nests are now rare, owing to changes in agricultural land-use patterns and environmental degradation. K.K. MUSTAFAH

A.P. announces promotions; Secretariat staff seek pay hike

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh government has issued orders enabling promotions for four categories of Swarna Ward Secretariat functionaries following the recent approval by the State Cabinet.

The order covers Ward Administrative Secretaries, Ward Data Processing Secretaries, Ward Sanitation and Environment Secretaries (Grade-II), and Ward Planning and Regulation Secretaries (Grade-II).

A.P. Village and Ward Secretariat Government Employees’ Association State president Sheik Abdul Rajak, who was detained at a police station throughout the day, told



Employees of Village and Ward Secretariats staging a protest in Vijayawada on Sunday. K.V.S. GIRI

The Hindu that the Government Order (G.O.), issued by the Municipal Administration and Urban Development Department on Sunday, was only a token gesture and would not benefit employees much.

“The promotions do not

lead to more than ₹2,000 increments for us. What use are the promotions if our salaries are not increased from the current ₹25,500 to ₹30,000?” he questioned.

Longstanding issue

The decision addresses a longstanding issue affecting employees recruited in 2019, many of whom have completed more than six years of service without receiving a promotion despite the promotional hierarchy having been notified by the government.

The decision is expected to benefit eligible employees working across Swarna Ward Secretariats functioning in the Urban Local Bodies.

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Researchers have identified a new species of the genus *Begonia* from the Western Ghats region in Kollam district of Keralam.

A research team of the Jawaharlal Nehru Tropical Botanic Garden and Research Institute (JNTBGRI) in Thiruvananthapuram spotted the plant during an exploration for collecting wild ornamental plants from the evergreen forests of Rosemala in Kollam.

The discovery has been reported at a time when the ghats region is back in the news in connection with the State government’s recommendations regarding Ecologically Sensitive Areas (ESA).

T.N. rescinds G.O. exempting Public Dept. from RTI Act

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

After facing severe backlash from political parties and activists, the Tamil Nadu government on Sunday decided to withdraw a controversial order exempting the Public (Law and Order) Department from the ambit of the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, on the ground that it was an intelligence and security organisation.

A Government Order (dated September 21) to this effect was issued by the Human Resources Management Department under Section 24(4) of the RTI Act and then notified in the Government Gazette. Minister for Energy Resources and Law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar wrote on X that the G.O. had been withdrawn. Speaking to reporters earlier in the day in Madurai, he had defended the order, saying that only certain provisions, including details of communal clashes, were kept out of the ambit of the RTI Act, given the sensitivity of the information.

AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran, environmental activist G. Sundarrajan of Poovulagin Nanbargal, and Arappor Iyakkam convener Jayaram Venkatesan opposed the G.O.

The Public (Law and Order) Department deals with subjects such as communal and caste clashes; the appointment of Commissions of Inquiry into law and order matters and follow-up action on their

The G.O., issued by the Department of Human Resources Management, drew severe backlash from political parties

recommendations; all matters relating to COFEPOSA and NSA detentions, including representations by detenus and *habeas corpus* petitions filed by detenus or on their behalf in the High Court and the Supreme Court; and the conduct of monthly law and order review meetings and special law and order meetings under the instructions of the Chief Secretary.

It includes examining inquiry reports into the opening of fire by the police and inquiry reports into deaths in police custody, police torture and deaths of remand prisoners; NHRC references relating to matters dealt with by the law and order wing; furnishing monthly reports on law and order and communal incidents to the Government of India; furnishing replies to Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha questions relating to law and order matters; dealing with agitations by students, agricultural labourers and political parties; requests for withdrawal of cases registered on political grounds, communal/caste clashes, political and student agitations; and matters relating to sanction of prosecution for defamatory articles, news items and speeches.



Begonia rajvikramanii

garden and the management of ex-situ plant conservation programmes at the institute.

A paper on the discovery and the plant’s identification as a new species by E.S. Santhosh Kumar, S.M. Shareef, P.P. Anusha and Rejitha Joseph of JNTBGRI has been published in the latest issue of *Phytotaxa*.

The plant was found growing on wet rocky cliffs. “This new species is currently known only from its type locality at Rosemala. It grows in wet habitats, particularly on rocky cliffs and road-cut walls, at elevations of approximately 200 metres-350 metres,” the paper said.

Its flowering and fruiting occurs between August and April.

T.N. former Minister moves HC to quash FIR in fraud case

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Former Tamil Nadu School Education Minister and DMK leader Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi has approached the Madras High Court with a plea to quash a First Information Report (FIR) registered by the Chennai Central Crime Branch (CCB) police on June 27, in connection with the alleged illegal collection of over ₹100 crore from various private schools in the State during the erstwhile DMK regime.

Justice V. Lakshminarayanan would be hearing on Monday a sub application filed by him to dispense with the production of original copy of the FIR. The CCB had booked the FIR against the president of an unregistered association of private schools B.T. Arasakumar and his alleged accomplices following a complaint lodged by D.C. Elangovan, president of a registered association.

In his complaint to the Greater Chennai Commissioner of Police A. Amalraj on June 23, Mr. Elangovan had alleged the prime accused, by claiming to be close to the ruling dispensation, had collected crores of rupees from the managements of various private schools for offering services such as obtaining



Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi

approvals for upgrading schools, gaining permanent recognition, and securing building plan approvals. Listing the names of 13 other individuals as the accomplices of the prime accused, the complainant had urged the police to probe into the role played by the former Minister too and initiate appropriate action.

Custodial interrogation Pursuant to the complaint, the CCB had arrested the prime accused on June 27 and subjected him to custodial interrogation.

Thereafter, he was detained under the Goondas Act on July 11 and his wife had challenged the preventive detention before the court by way of a *habeas corpus* petition. She claimed a civil dispute between office-bearers of two associations had been given a criminal colour.

Bank unions defer three-day nationwide strike after meeting

Decision comes after hour-long online meeting with bank managements; high-level committee to deliberate on demand for five-day banking week

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

Bank unions on Sunday deferred the proposed three-day nationwide strike after a meeting with bank managements.

“All banks will function normally now. We had three main demands. Discussion was held on all of them in a meeting held at 9.30 p.m. today [Sunday]. We had three main demands. One of them was for a five-day working week. Decision has been taken to immediately form a high-level committee of IBA [Indian Banks’ Association] and UFBU [United Forum of Bank Unions] to deliberate on the issue and to see how it can be implemented,” C.H. Venkatachalam, general secretary of the All India Bank Employees Association (AIBEA) told *The Hindu*.

Seven representatives of banking unions and six banking executives were present for the online meeting which lasted about an hour. The UFBU issued a circular late on Saturday night announcing that an understanding had



Seven representatives of banking unions and six banking executives were present for the online meeting. - V. RAJU

been reached with the IBA.

“As regards the PLI Scheme for Scale IV and above officers, the discussions can start with IBA to propose modifications to the Government in the scheme to address the observations of the Unions/Associations. The residual issues as listed in the minutes dated 8.3.2024 will be discussed between the parties for expeditious resolution,” the circular issued by the UFBU stated.

Devidas Tuljapurkar, chairperson of the All India Bank of Maharashtra Employees’ Federation, expressed satisfaction at the outcome of the meeting. “The demand for a five-day week has been long pending. By accepting to form a

committee, a positive step has been taken to find out how it can be implemented in consultation with all stakeholders, particularly the customers, so that they are not inconvenienced,” he told *The Hindu*.

The UFBU, an umbrella body representing seven bank employees’ and officers’ unions, had announced a three-day strike from September 28 to 30.

Besides five-day banking, unions had also sought the resolution of several other issues, including the updating and improvement of pension benefits and an option for employees covered under the National Pension System (NPS) to switch to the Old Pension Scheme (OPS).

India, Canada set to take ties to ‘higher level’: Jaishankar

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

India and Canada are preparing to take their relationship “to a higher level”, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said after holding a “productive discussion” with his Canadian counterpart, Anita Anand, on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) session.

“Always a pleasure to meet FM @AnitaAnandMP of Canada #UNGA81. A productive discussion as we prepare to take the relationship to a higher level,” Mr. Jaishankar said on Saturday in a post on X.

Earlier this week, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said at the UN that Prime Minister Narendra Modi is expected to visit Canada around December this year, noting that Ottawa is making “good progress” in its trade negotiations with India.

“We are making good progress in our trade negotiations with India. It is an exceptionally important relationship on many many levels, people-to-people levels, security levels, and also trade and economic [levels],” Mr. Carney said at a press conference on September 22 on the sidelines of the UNGA.

India and Canada had committed at the G-20 last



S. Jaishankar with Anita Anand in New York, PTI

year to “look to conclude negotiations by the G20 this year”, said Mr. Carney while responding to questions on when Mr. Modi would visit Canada and how close Ottawa was to concluding a free-trade agreement with India, aimed at more than doubling bilateral trade to 70 billion Canadian dollars annually by 2030.

Amid discussions in India regarding diversification of its energy sources, Mr. Jaishankar also met Venezuela Foreign Minister Felix Plasencia Gonzalez on the UNGA sidelines. After the meeting, he said: “Our energy ties are gaining momentum, besides other areas of bilateral cooperation. We also discussed current regional issues.”

He also met Belarus Foreign Minister Maxim Ryzhenkov and his Mexican counterpart, Roberto Velasco Alvarez of Mexico.

Russia backs India’s bid for permanent UNSC seat

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

Russia has backed India’s candidature for a permanent seat in the United Nations Security Council (UNSC), saying that any reform of the UN body cannot involve additional seats being allocated to Western countries, especially Germany and Japan.

“Our principled approach is the following: UN Security Council reform cannot involve any additional seats being allocated to Western countries, especially to Germany and Japan, who are now on the path to militarism and revanchism,” Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov said in his address to the UN General Assembly.

Alliance support “We are in favour of broadening the representation of Asia, Africa, and Latin America. We support Brazil’s and India’s candidatures for a permanent seat, and at the same time, I wish to emphasise this: we must satisfy the interests of the African continent,” he said. Mr. Lavrov added that through its foreign policy, “Russia is trying to fix the situation in the world, working together with its allies and strategic partners: the BRICS, the SCO, and the Eurasian Economic Union”.

Delhi Minister slaps aide of AAP MLA; Kejriwal demands his arrest

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi Public Works Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh slapped the aide of Aam Aadmi Party Tilak Nagar MLA Jarnail Singh on Sunday during an inspection of a newly laid road on the Vikaspuri section of Outer Ring Road.

A video of the alleged incident was circulated by the AAP, with its party chief Arvind Kejriwal seeking the Minister’s arrest. Mr. Parvesh said the AAP workers at the site abused him and his family, which made him react like “any common man would do”.

During the inspection, the PWD Minister was joined by the MLA, who along with party workers peeled off portions of the newly laid road on the Vikaspuri section with their hands and questioned the Minister about the quality of the work. Posing questions to the Minister, they said the new road would not last longer than 15 days.

On being cornered by



AAP MLA Jarnail Singh speaks to police officers after the incident in Tilak Nagar, New Delhi, on Sunday. ANI VIDEO GRAB

the MLA and residents, the Minister is seen in the video heading back to his car, when he confronts a person who is recording the proceedings. Mr. Parvesh is then seen pushing the camera away with his left hand and slapping the person on his face with his right hand before security personnel intervened.

Releasing a video to “expose the truth being spread by the AAP” regarding the incident, the Minister later accused the AAP MLA of demanding a commission from the road contractor. He said that he

came to inspect the site on his own in view of the allegations against the MLA.

“People of the area were very happy with the quality of the road and told me that for 15 years, the road had been broken. The BJP is repairing roads that were untouched during the AAP’s regime and the party was not able to stomach it,” Mr. Parvesh said. He added that the BJP government would conduct third-party audits of works done and ensure its quality through core-cutting tests but will not tolerate disrespectful behaviour or de-

mand for commissions.

Demanding action against the Minister, MLA Jarnail Singh said the AAP wanted the Delhi Police Commissioner to “break free from external pressure” and take the same legal action against the Minister as in the case of any other criminal. “The Delhi Police were present at the site when the incident occurred but instead of apprehending the Minister, they helped him escape,” Mr. Jarnail alleged. The Delhi Police said complaints had been received from both sides. “Preliminary probe is under way after which the FIR may be filed,” West Delhi DCP Swami Hareshwar V. said.

Posting the video, several senior AAP leaders called for the Minister’s arrest and said the “true face” of the BJP had been exposed. “A Minister of Modiji slapped a young man publicly for exposing the corruption in road construction. I will go to Tilak Nagar tomorrow [Monday] and inspect,” Mr. Kejriwal posted.

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Days after members of the U.S. Congress passed a new Russia sanctions law targeting India and other oil importers of Russian crude oil, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri on Sunday met with a five-member Congressional Delegation headed by the U.S. House Foreign Affairs Committee Chair Brian Mast.

The delegation included Bill co-sponsor Jimmy Patronis, Republican representative James Gallagher, and Democrat Haley Stevens, both of whom voted in favour of it, as well as Shri Thanedar, an Indian-born U.S. lawmaker, who had voted against the Bill.

The meeting follows days after External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar raised India’s concerns about possible sanctions with U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio in New York, and Mr. Misri discussed the issue with U.S. Undersecretary of State for Political Affairs Allison Hooker.



Wide-ranging talks: Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri during the meeting with the U.S. Congressional delegation. PTI

The Lindsey O. Graham Sanctions against Russia and Iran Act (SRIA), passed in the U.S. Congress on September 16, mandates that U.S. President Donald Trump impose up to 100% sanctions on countries that buy Russian oil and extends sanctions on trade with Iran.

A determination on what kind of sanctions, if any, would be imposed on India is expected to be made next month, with a 30-day deadline pending. Officials did not comment on whether Mr. Misri discussed or received any as-

surances on a waiver of the sanctions that can be granted under certain conditions.

“Discussions covered the entire gamut of India-U.S. relations, including the recently enacted SRIA legislation and the future trajectory of the relationship,” Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in a post about the meeting that was held at Mr. Misri’s residence. “They also exchanged views on international issues of mutual concern, energy security, counter-terrorism and

freedom of navigation,” he added.

Mr. Mast is an American Army veteran who lost both his legs in a blast in Kandahar in 2010. He works on counter-terrorism issues and has an interest in South Asia. During the India-Pakistan conflict in May 2025, Mr. Mast said in an interview that he had spoken to “both sides”, and sought de-escalation after India’s strikes on Pakistan following the Pahalgam terror attacks. He has also advocated sanctions on Russia and supports secondary sanctions that have now been proposed against China and India, which are major buyers of Russian oil. He has criticised China in particular for military supplies to Russia during the war in Ukraine.

Mr. Thanedar was the only member of the delegation who voted against the Bill, and was one of five Indian-Americans who opposed it, largely over concerns about the powers it would grant the U.S. President.

Bricks, eggs hurled at Tripura ex-CM’s car

Syed Sajjad Ali
AGARTALA

The CPI(M) and Congress condemned the attack on the convoy of former Chief Minister Manik Sarkar at Bamutia assembly constituency in west Tripura on Sunday. Bricks and eggs were thrown at the vehicle of Mr. Sarkar and security escorts.

Both the Opposition parties described the incident as a “fallout of the BJP’s frustration”, claiming the party is fast losing its support base in the State. They also linked the inci-

dent with recent controversies concerning the Election Commission.

The CPI(M) politburo member was not injured, but the car in which he was travelling was slightly damaged. The crowd was protesting against Mr. Sarkar’s arrival in the area to attend a party meeting.

Mr. Sarkar said that the BJP is now completely disconnected with the people and desperate to silence the voices of dissent.

Congress leader and former Health Minister Sudip Roy Barman condemned the incident.

Wangchuk seeks higher compensation for families of 2025 Leh protest victims

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, championing the cause of greater constitutional guarantees for Ladakh, on Sunday sought accountability and demanded that the findings of the judicial inquiry into the violence in Leh in September 2025, which left four dead and around 80 injured, be made public.

“Almost a year later, Ladakh is still waiting for the findings. Who ordered the firing? Were all the prescribed stages of crowd



Sonam Wangchuk

control exhausted before live ammunition was used? Why were people hit in vital parts of their bodies? That is exactly why a judicial inquiry was constitut-

ed... Let the people know the truth,” said Mr. Wangchuk, who was arrested under the National Security Act (NSA) on September 27. Mr. Wangchuk was referring to the killing of four civilians in Leh on September 24, 2025 allegedly in firing by security forces during an agitation over the demand for Statehood, and Ladakh’s inclusion in the Sixth Schedule of the Indian Constitution.

He said those who exercised extraordinary powers must carry extraordinary responsibility for how those powers were used.

He also questioned the ₹15 lakh compensation announced by the Ladakh administration for the families of the victims. “Can ₹15 lakh ever compensate a mother for her son, a wife for her husband, or children for their father,” he said. The activist demanded the affected Ladakhi families be compensated based on the same principle as those affected by the NEET paper leak, “who were assured ₹1 crore”.

Mr. Wangchuk also questioned the cases filed against 87 locals in connection with the Leh violence.

JKCA holds general meet after 10 years

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Mired in legal wranglings, the J&K Cricket Association (JKCA) held its Annual General Meeting in Jammu on Sunday after a gap of nearly 10 years and discussed the hosting of the Irani Cup being held for the first time in Kashmir from October 1 to 5.

The meeting was held after a court order on September 26.

“The meeting stressed the importance of unity, collective responsibility, and a positive approach

among all stakeholders to further strengthen and promote cricket across J&K. The members expressed their commitment to working together to build on recent achievements and take J&K cricket to greater heights,” a JKCA spokesperson.

A local court in Jammu in a ruling on Saturday permitted the JKCA to hold the meeting. Javed Ahmad Kitab, who was suspended in July as president of the JKCA, had petitioned the court with a claim that he was still “the elected president of the JKCA”.

CJP leader, 41 volunteers detained by Assam Police

They were released in the evening; CJP spokesperson says the detainees were not served with any legal notice; CJP wanted to talk about fixing the pathetic condition of schools in Assam, he says

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Assam Police on Sunday detained Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka and several others from a private residence in Guwahati. They were released later in the evening.

According to CJP spokesperson Anish Gawande, the others included 41 local volunteers and Mr. Ranka's associates, Ankit Bharadwaj and Prem Aakash.

"Six of those detained along with Ashutosh Ranka are women. They were taken to the [Dispur] police station from a private residence, where a meet-up of CJP volunteers was scheduled," Mr. Gawande told presspersons.

"The illegal detention by Assam Police has finally ended. We have asked Police to go and drop us from where we were picked up illegally in the first place," Mr. Ranka said in a post on



Rallying cry: CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka at a protest ahead of its first regional volunteers' meeting in Assam on Sunday. PTI

X after being released along with the other detainees.

The CJP leaders and volunteers were not served with any legal notice, and they were also not told which sections of the law they had been detained under, Mr. Gawande said.

"This is nothing short of jungle raj under Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who is afraid of any and all kind of dissent," Mr. Gawande said.

All the CJP wanted to talk about was fixing the pathetic condition of schools in Assam, which do not have fans, classrooms, and teachers, he said.

"We wanted to talk about the way people have been evicted from Kaziranga, their lands taken, and activists arrested. We wanted to talk about the illegal redrawing of the election (constituency) boundaries in Assam," he said.

The CJP alleged that there had been a pattern in Assam "happening for too long".

"You have seen what happened with land rights activist Pranab Doley, who was arrested and then detained under the National Security Act. You have seen how the government intimidates civil society activists in Assam," Mr. Gawande said.

'Chief Minister is afraid' Earlier in the day, Mr. Ranka asked why the Chief Minister was afraid of being exposed.

"The Chief Minister is scared that if we show the schools here, the country will know the reality. He is afraid that people will know how their rights were being snatched in Kaziranga for the benefit of the corporates. But we are not afraid of him. We know that he won the Assembly election by redrawing boundaries of constituencies," Mr. Ranka said.

CPI(M) leader, AAP chief discuss EC row, ED action against ex-Keralam CM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of the INDIA bloc meeting scheduled for September 30 to discuss the functioning of the Election Commission, CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby met Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convenor and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal in Delhi on Sunday.

The leaders discussed the recent report on Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar allegedly ignoring objections raised by the two Election Commissioners on the special intensive revision exercise and the Enforcement Directorate's action against former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan.

The meeting comes days after Mr. Baby wrote to INDIA bloc parties and other non-NDA parties seeking a joint discussion on developments following reports of differences within the poll panel over the SIR exercise. Setting aside three-decade-old differences,



CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby at Aam Aadmi Party national convenor Arvind Kejriwal's residence in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

Mr. Baby spoke to the chairperson of the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress, Mamata Banerjee, who agreed that the situation warranted coordinated action.

Meeting agenda

Mr. Baby said his primary purpose was to invite Mr. Kejriwal to participate in the Left campaign against the alleged misuse of Central investigation agencies. He underlined that the Enforcement Directorate, which had been used against Mr. Kejriwal and his colleague Manish Sisodia, was now being deployed

against former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan in what he described as a sustained attempt to tarnish his image. The two leaders also discussed the "authoritarian manner" in which Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was functioning and the need for a united Opposition effort to expose his alleged wrongdoing.

The INDIA bloc meeting is expected to discuss the functioning of the Election Commission, the SIR exercise, and the Opposition's course of action, including seeking the removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

Mamata camp leader faces attack twice in two days

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Beleghata MLA Kunal Ghosh was allegedly attacked on Sunday and his vehicle was damaged by unidentified miscreants.

This was the second attack on the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) leader in two days. Mr. Ghosh was attacked at Uttarpara in Hooghly district on Saturday when he was on the way to attend a meeting called by former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

"Today I was once again the target of an attempted murder. It all happened in the city of Kolkata, in broad daylight and on a Sunday, when I was on my way to attend a programme as an MLA. They were armed; they smashed the car window and tried to drag me out, brandishing revolvers. My security personnel had to draw their weapons," Mr. Ghosh said.

The journalist-turned-politician lodged a complaint at the Narkeldanga police station.

CEC row: Suvendu slams Mamata for joining hands with the CPI(M)

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Amid the controversy surrounding the Election Commission (EC), West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Sunday criticised former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee for joining hands with the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and accused her of deliberately creating confusion over the role of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

"The Opposition is deliberately creating confusion and controversy over a recent newspaper report," the Chief Minister said.

CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby had approached Ms. Banerjee over the ongoing controversy, and Ms. Banerjee had agreed that her party and the CPI(M) were on the same page in this matter. She said that she had a discussion with Congress leaders and that the Opposition would hold a

meeting on the issue. Leaders of the Opposition INDIA bloc are likely to meet on September 30.

"Trinamool was formed to end the atrocities and injustice of 34 years of CPI(M) rule. The same CPI(M) has now become its friend," Mr. Adhikari said.

His remarks came a day after Ms. Banerjee sharpened her attack on Mr. Kumar, alleging that the SIR was being used to help the BJP capture Bengal and demanded fresh elections with the pre-SIR voter list.

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJI to stay SIR, start suo motu proceedings on EC conduct

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Over 2,000 citizens across the country have signed an open letter to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant to initiate *suo motu* proceedings against the operational and administrative conduct of the Election Commission of India regarding the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise and the deployment of ECINet.

The letter seeks the im-

mediate stay and rescission of the SIR exercise across all States and Union Territories pending a thorough, independent judicial review of its legality and procedural integrity in light of the new facts that have emerged.

They have also sought an independent, court-monitored investigation into allegations of arbitrary, unauthorised changes made to voter registration software/forms. The open letter has sought a direc-

tion from the court for "appropriate penal/procedural action against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and officials for overriding statutory procedures and disregarding the constitutional mandate of the multi-member Commission".

The signatories have also sought a comprehensive security and legal audit of the ECINet software platform by an independent expert committee appointed by the top court to res-

tore decentralised control to local Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) as mandated by law and verify whether any persons other than statutory officers had access to the platform.

The letter urged the court's intervention to order the immediate reinstatement of voters whose names were deleted.

"When the institutional safeguards designed to protect the electoral roll are compromised from

within, judicial intervention becomes vital to preserve public faith in the democratic process," the letter said.

The signatories include academic Aditya Nigam, filmmaker Aditya Seth, Admiral Vishnu Bhagwat (retired), retired IAS officer Aditi Mehta, activists Amrita Johri and Anjali Bhardwaj, former DU professor Anita Rampal, retired JNU Professor Nivedita Menon, advocate Prashant Bhushan and actor Prakash Raj.

BJP slams Rahul over SIR, accuses Opposition parties of maligning institutions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The BJP on Sunday fielded its Chief Ministers and stepped up its attack on the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, the Congress, and its allies over the special intensive revision (SIR), accusing them of making unsubstantiated claims.

Alleging that Mr. Gandhi and other Opposition leaders were conspiring to malign the country's constitutional institutions, the BJP said the Election Commission had already issued a press note and a fact-based clarification of the "fabricated allegations".

"Despite this, the Congress and its allies, frustrated by their repeated electoral defeats, remain determined to undermine constitutional propriety in an attempt to conceal their failures. From North to South and East to West, this misinformation aimed at weakening the country's democratic framework and creating anarchy is being strongly countered across the nation," the party said in a statement.

Chief Ministers Yogi Adityanath, Devendra Fadnavis, Himanta Biswa Sarma, Bhajan Lal Sharma, Bhupendra Patel, Nayab Singh Saini, Vishnu Deo Sai,



When Congress wins elections, it hails the outcome as a victory of democracy, but makes baseless claims of vote theft after a defeat

BHUPENDRA PATEL
Gujarat Chief Minister

Pushkar Singh Dhami, Rekha Gupta, Samrat Choudhary, Mohan Yadav and Suwendu Adhikari hit out at the Congress.

Mr. Fadnavis accused Mr. Gandhi of seeking to discredit institutions under the guise of defending the Constitution and deliberately creating confusion and chaos by repeatedly questioning constitutional bodies. "There has been no vote theft, Rahul Gandhi's mind has been stolen," he said.

Yogi seeks apology

Alleging that the Opposition parties had created confusion over the SIR, Mr. Adityanath sought an apology from the Congress and its allies.

Mr. Sarma described the Opposition as an "alliance of defeated people", while Mr. Yadav alleged that Mr. Gandhi was spreading falsehoods after failing to manage his party. Mr. Sai said that "frustrated after losing more than 100 elec-

tions", the Congress had now "resorted to anti-national conduct".

Ms. Gupta demanded an apology, accusing the Opposition of "creating this baseless controversy to divert attention from its failures, its betrayal of the country and the development works being undertaken".

Mr. Patel slammed the Congress's "double standards" and said that when the Congress won elections, it hailed the outcome as a victory of democracy, but would make baseless claims of vote theft and electoral malpractice after a loss.

Mr. Adhikari said the Congress supported SIR in Kerala because it won there but opposed it in West Bengal after losing the election.

He said judicial officers were dealing with names rejected due to logical discrepancies, adding that the Opposition was misleading the public.

Police say no to CJP protest in Mumbai on October 2

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Mumbai police have denied permission to the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) to hold a protest against the Election Commission at Shivaji Park on October 2, officials said on Sunday.

The police cited court-imposed curbs on non-sporting activities at the ground, lack of BMC permission, and concerns over noise and traffic congestion as the reasons.

The Shivaji Park police conveyed the decision in a letter dated September 27 addressed to CJP national organisation in-charge Ajinkya Shinde. The party had sought permission to hold the protest at Shivaji Park in Dadar from 3 pm to 9 pm on October 2.

However, police have not barred the CJP from holding a protest elsewhere in Mumbai. The organisation has been told that if it wants to organise the agitation at another location in the city, it can approach the police station concerned or the competent police authority for permission.

The October 2 CJP protest has also acquired a wider political dimension. The Shiv Sena (UBT) is expected to participate in the agitation, according to a report published on Sunday.

Maharashtra begins crop inspection in drought-hit taluks; CM promises aid

Press Trust of India
NAGPUR

The Maharashtra government has begun work on preparing crop inspection reports after declaring 265 taluks drought-affected, and it will provide appropriate assistance to affected farmers soon, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said on Sunday.

He said the government is considering the possibility of El Niño peaking in next February. "We should be ready to face troubles if it intensifies," he said.

The State government on Saturday declared drought in 265 of its 358 taluks, or 74% of the State amid rainfall deficit and announced various relief measures, including crop loan restructuring, land revenue concessions, and power bill subsidies.

Mr. Fadnavis said the State government had received complaints about the exclusion of some taluks from the drought criterion; however, the numbers are very few.

Special session sought

NCP (SP) chief and former Union Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar demanded that a three-day special session of the Assembly be convened to address the severe drought situation and pass immediate relief



Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis inspecting areas affected by drought at Mohagavhan in Washim on September 24. ANI

measures, including farm loan waiver, before the upcoming festivals.

In a letter to Mr. Fadnavis, he urged the State government to declare all remaining drought-affected taluks drought-hit and waive land revenue across the impacted regions.

Emphasising the need for urgent direct financial intervention, he said ₹1 lakh per hectare should be deposited into the bank accounts of affected farmers, alongside ₹25,000 for farm labourers. Tehsildars should be allowed to sanction drinking water tankers immediately, apart from government tankers for large orchard areas.

Data centre plan

The Congress also raised questions over the State government's policy of "aggressively expanding

the data-centre industry". "When nearly three-fourths of Maharashtra is under drought, what is the government's plan to ensure that the State's water resources are not diverted away from farmers and ordinary citizens to fuel this massive data-centre expansion?" asked Congress' media and publicity department head Pawan Kherra.

The government is reportedly planning a system where municipal corporations treat sewage, the Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation further purifies it, and the reclaimed water is then sold to data centres and other industries, he said.

In a State like Maharashtra, which has one of India's highest farmer-suicide rates, who has the first right over water – farmers or data centres, he asked.

'Confident that Vijay will back Rahul as PM candidate'

K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president B. Manickam Tagore has expressed the hope that TVK president and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay will also endorse Congress leader Rahul Gandhi as the INDIA bloc's prime ministerial candidate for the Lok Sabha polls in 2029.

In an interview with *The Hindu*, he exuded confidence that Mr. Vijay would make such an announcement before the election.

When pointed out that the TVK's second-line leaders were already projecting Mr. Vijay as the "future Prime Minister", he said such slogans were no longer being raised. "A few people in the party were expressing their personal wish. They are not talking about it now. When the elections arrive, the TVK chief will announce who they are supporting. The Tamil Nadu Congress will contest the elections projecting Rahul Gandhi, and I am 100% confident that Mr. Vijay will support it," Mr. Tagore said.

He said the DMK, which exited the INDIA bloc after the Congress joined the TVK-led Ministry post-Assembly polls, will not win the Lok Sabha elections even if it forms a [national-level] third front.

INBRIEF



3-storey building collapses in Haryana, 4 dead, 12 injured

Four people died while more than ten were injured when a three-storeyed building under construction collapsed at Dhulkot village near Ambala City in Haryana on Sunday, officials said. The incident unfolded in the late afternoon when the concrete slab (lintel) for the roof was being cast on the first floor, prompting locals to initiate rescue efforts before informing the police and emergency services. One of the injured workers claimed that some labourers were working on the ground floor, while others were engaged in the casting work above. Ambala Civil Surgeon Renu Beri told reporters that 12 injured labourers were brought to the hospital, of whom five are still admitted, two were discharged on request, while the others were discharged after first aid. PTI

IndiGo A321 plane involved in another tail strike

An IndiGo Airbus A321 was involved in yet another tail strike at Bengaluru airport on Sunday, marking at least the ninth known such incident involving the airline's A321 fleet. In a statement, IndiGo said an "abnormal runway contact" occurred during "gusty wind conditions" in Bengaluru. The aircraft was operating a flight from Guwahati. It aborted its initial landing attempt at Bengaluru airport before making a final landing at 12.15 p.m., industry sources said. A tail strike occurs when the rear section of an aircraft comes into contact with the runway during landing, take-off, or a go-around.

Census 2027 is a 'national responsibility', says Modi

Data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded during the nationwide exercise, PM says in *Mann Ki Baat*; he also highlights Indian armed forces' decisive response to terror attacks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

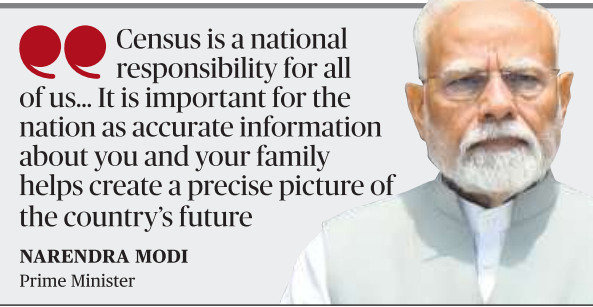
Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday described Census 2027 as a national responsibility requiring public participation. With over 32 crore families recorded and 2.6 crore people having self-enumerated digitally, he said accurate information about people and their families would help create a precise picture of the country's future.

During his *Mann Ki Baat* address, Mr. Modi said: "The facility to self-register your Census details is very convenient. You can register information about yourself and your family from your mobile itself."

"The first phase of this exercise is nearly complete across all States and Union Territories; data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded," he said.

Over 2.6 crore people had already entered their details on the Census portal through mobile phones without uploading any documents, he added.

During his address, Mr. Modi paid tributes to the victims of the September



2008 Delhi serial blasts, the 26/11 Mumbai attack and the 9/11 U.S. terrorist attacks.

Recalling India's surgical strike on September 28-29, 2016, he said the Indian Army demonstrated a decisive response by crossing the Line of Control to target terrorist hideouts in Pakistan. He highlighted the Balakot air strike and Operation Sindoor as instances of India's zero-tolerance counter-terrorism approach.

On the "Somnath Swabhimani Parv", he said Mahmud of Ghazni demolished the Somnath Temple for the first time in 1026 and the same year, the Sun Temple in Gujarat's Modherna was also attacked and destroyed. He said despite invasions and destruction of temples, the people and rulers of that period did

not lose their resolve and rebuilt them.

Praise for expert

Mr. Modi hailed the contribution of A. Selvaraju, associated with the Department of Tamil Studies at a college in Manapparai in Tamil Nadu's Tiruchirappalli.

He said Mr. Selvaraju discovered several sculptures and ancient temples, helping people understand and connect with the past.

Referring to the recently concluded Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations, Mr. Modi noted that India's spiritual and cultural heritage transcended national boundaries, citing Thailand resident

Panthoun Thirkhanon's decades-long study and promotion of Ganesha traditions in that country.

With Mahatma Gandhi's

birth anniversary approaching on October 2, he said cleanliness was one of Gandhiji's guiding principles.

Green drive

On environment conservation, he noted the achievements made in the Sonai Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary, Assam, where land was cleared of encroachment for the once-displaced elephants to return to their natural habitat.

In West Bengal's Sundarbans, some women from Jharkhali — most of whom lost their husbands to tiger attacks — were creating mangrove forests, which were not only serving as a natural protective shield for villages but also creating income opportunities, Mr. Modi said.

Stating that the month of September is dedicated to the fight against malnutrition, he noted that Chhattisgarh was promoting *moringa* through "*Har Ghar Munga*"; Gujarat was encouraging nutritious millet dishes through "*Vangi Spardha*"; Maharashtra was conducting nutrition-awareness campaigns; and Mizoram was supporting "*Poshan Vatikas*".

PM pays tribute to Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday paid tribute to former Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) international working president Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary, describing him as an "organisational genius" and recalling his "pivotal role" in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement.

In an op-ed article, Mr. Modi recalled his many interactions with Singhal, who was born on September 27, 1926, and passed away on November 17, 2015. "I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok Ji and receive his affection," Mr. Modi wrote.

"One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981, when I was a young *Karyakarta* going about the organisational duties given to me. I received a handwritten letter from him," he added. "Naturally, it was a noteworthy moment for me." Mr. Modi wrote about Singhal both as a person as well as an administrator.

He recalled how he saw Singhal work hard on various projects that involved "long and often difficult travels".

"His mind was constant-

He hailed the former VHP international working president's 'pivotal role' in Ram Janmabhoomi movement

ly running, thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society," Mr. Modi recalled. "Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok Ji was either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding *Karyakartas* to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable."

Mr. Modi highlighted Singhal's role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. "Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991," he asked. "Or the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok Ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible." "He would have been the happiest person on seeing the Ram Mandir take shape in Ayodhya," Mr. Modi wrote.

Tribal students to embark on 180-km march to Mumbai

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
NASHIK

Hundreds of tribal students in Maharashtra will embark on a nearly 180-km march from Nashik to Mumbai on Monday, pressing the government to address their demands for better facilities, safety, and accountability in government-run residential schools.

Spearheaded by the Sakal Adivasi Vidyarthi Andolan Kruti Samiti, the long march comes 40 days after a sit-in at the Idgah Maidan in Nashik. The protest continues, with a small slate declaring the day of protest hanging from the ceiling of a temporary pandal. Posters of Birsu Munda, Bhagat Singh and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar surround the protesters as they take turns to sit on strike.

Among the demands of the protesters are the resig-



Tribal students at the sit-in at Nashik's Idgah Maidan. The protest has been going on for the past 40 days. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

nation of Maharashtra Tribal Development Minister Ashok Uike, the transfer of the Tribal Development Department's Secretary and Commissioner, basic facilities in tribal schools and hostels, an independent inquiry into tribal students' deaths at residential schools, and financial assistance for victims.

"Last month, the government held discussions with protesters from Pune and Nagpur. Tribals from

Nashik did not join them. The government gave them false promises. We are in touch with tribals from Nashik, Khandesh, North Maharashtra, Marathwada, and Vidarbha. We expect around 1,500 students to join us on the first day of the protest march," tribal leader Rahul Pawra told *The Hindu*. Protesters also raised concerns over the food provided by central kitchens to tribal schools.

Student's death can't be seen in isolation: IIT-Bombay alumni

Vinaya Vilas Deshpande
MUMBAI

The death by suicide of Sahil Wakode cannot be viewed in isolation, alumni of Indian Institute of Technology-Bombay (IITB) said on Sunday. The incident pointed to a deeper problem within the academic environment, they said. In a letter written to the Director of the institute, a group of alumni have also expressed concerns over the increasingly "militarised campus" during exams. Calling for immediate, comprehensive reforms, they sought a survey of the students' mental health and a humane approach to deal with instances of misconduct.

The alumni expressed deep anguish about a series of deaths by suicide at the institute. The 10 de-

mands put forth by them include a call for an immediate and impartial investigation into specific allegations of caste-based harassment and improved mental health support, including mandatory faculty sensitisation.

"We sincerely hope that the institute will take concrete steps to ensure that the academic climate at IITB is egalitarian, humane and conducive to intellectual growth. This requires addressing the caste, class and gender-based inequalities... that are deeply embedded in our society and can manifest within academic institutions," the letter, accessed by *The Hindu*, stated.

[Those in distress may contact Sanjivini, Society for Mental Health suicide prevention helpline: 011-40769002.]

Boeing finds glitch in guidance system of some 737-MAX planes

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Boeing has detected a software issue in some of its B737-MAX planes that could result in disengagement of the automated flight guidance system after a missed landing approach, and the aircraft maker is working on a permanent solution, according to sources.

In India, there are 96 Boeing 737-MAX planes operated by Air India Express (53) and Akasa Air (43).

"Last month, we informed all 737 operators about a software issue where pilots may experience a reduction in automation during a landing scenario. We shared information with operators that reinforced existing pilot procedures for safely handling such cases," the spokesperson said in a statement.



Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system as a precautionary measure to address the issue. FILE PHOTO

Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system following a missed approach as a precautionary measure to address the issue, sources said.

"We are closely coordinating with Boeing and can confirm that there is no impact to the safety of Akasa Air operations. Our aircraft continue to operate safely in accordance with established procedures and applicable regulatory requirements," an airline

spokesperson said in a statement.

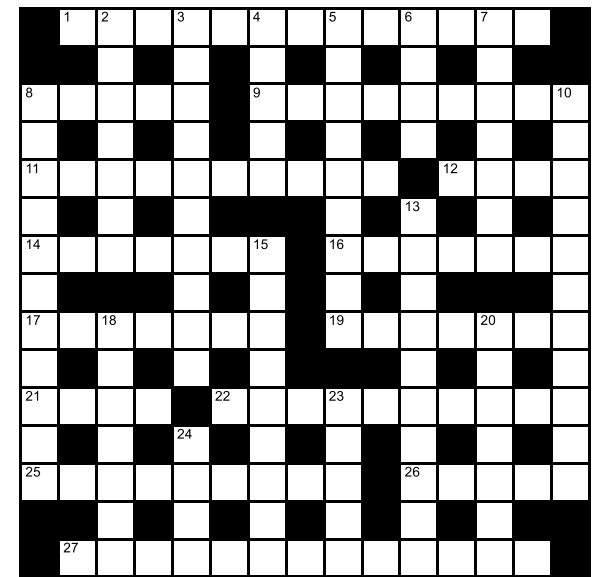
However, the carrier did not specifically mention whether any of its Boeing 737-MAX planes had been impacted due to the issue. There was no response from Air India Express.

There was no immediate response from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation on whether it was probing the issue and whether any advisory was issued to airlines.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14909 (set by Dr. X)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

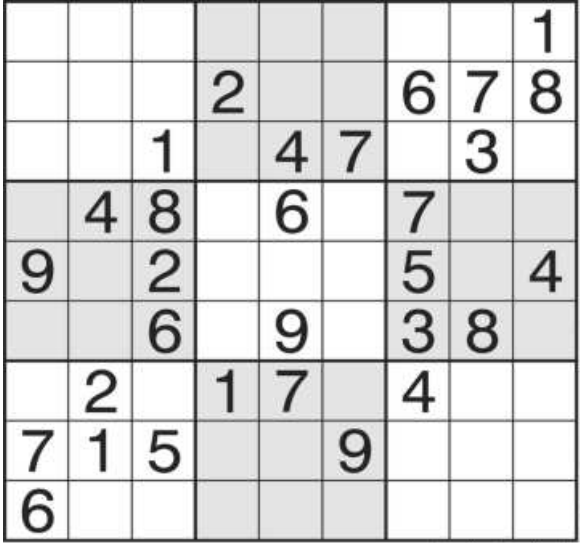


- 16 Asserting briefly about making a bloomer (7)
- 17 Deceiver cheers up after ensnaring maiden (7)
- 19 Small tin can made of tin (7)
- 21 Lover starts to cuddle at first (4)
- 22 Liaison at rave after consuming cocaine - becoming rebellious (10)
- 25 Cause a commotion in bar, catching date embracing hot lady (5,4)
- 26 Lyric poet turned very tense, entertaining princess (5)
- 27 Art of artfully reshaping with latest in 3D CGI (7,6)

- Down
- 2 Runner's not at all well, close to collapse (7)
 - 3 Love smart American couple welcoming members at launch individually (3,2,1,4)
 - 4 Content of natural ginseng gum (5)
 - 5 Desires remuneration after end of therapy (9)
 - 6 Bishop, one wearing outsize sashes (4)
 - 7 Model consuming ecstasy with posh fellow turned miserable (7)
 - 8 Specialist beginning to chat about treatment of neurosis (11)
 - 10 Knight in position trapping one's rook with clean moves (3,8)
 - 13 Goad union's ridiculous dinosaurs (10)
 - 15 Peaceful, having good time on island's national park (9)
 - 18 Woman drinking wine, becoming more reckless (7)
 - 20 Nudging to control one talking loudly (7)
 - 23 Relaxed in food shop in retreat, cuddling date (5)
 - 24 Look at bottom of pump for leak (4)

- Across
- 1 Where one sees the letter E explicitly? (2,2,4,5)
 - 8 Advance to save boy in valley (5)
 - 9 Delighted with production of oil by American plant (9)
 - 11 Teen in inn excited about boy finally giving number (6-4)
 - 12 Starts to appreciate fine African rhino from a distance (4)
 - 14 Rose edited series about Greek mythological character (7)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Rama's justification

Dharma is sukshma, its subtle meanings difficult to grasp. We should follow what our Acharyas advise us to follow, said Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar in a discourse. Only those who practise dharma must talk about it. Rama was qualified to talk about dharma, because He was a practitioner of dharma. Vaali questions the propriety of Rama's action of shooting an arrow at him (Vaali) from behind, and wonders if His act is dharmic. Rama explains what dharma is to Vaali. Vaali's foremost sin is misbehaviour towards Sugreeva's wife. Vaali is the elder brother of Sugreeva and is therefore like a father to him. He should have treated Sugreeva as he would his son. Would it be right for a man to make his son's wife his own? Vaali, by his conduct towards Sugreeva's wife, had committed a very grave sin. Just as one must not have lustful thoughts about one's daughter or sister, likewise one must not have such thoughts about one's brother's wife.

Having broken such a fundamental rule, how could Vaali talk about dharma and hope for clemency? Dharma sastras say that a king who metes out proper punishment for a crime or a sin will enter heaven. If a thief or a sinner is punished by his king, he escapes hell. But a king who fails to punish a wrongdoer will definitely go to hell, according to the dharma sastras. As for killing Vaali from behind, do hunters have to face animals before killing them, asks Rama. Vaali has been claiming that what he did was right according to vanara dharma. If he took refuge behind the argument that he was an animal, then using the same argument, Rama could say He was justified in hitting Vaali from behind.



In need of an overhaul

ECI's response is mere damage control, the SIR's ill-effects must be undone

The Election Commission of India's (ECI) press note on Saturday, following revelations that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had recorded 14 objections to decisions under Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, reads like damage control to manage perceptions. It concedes their complaints, but only administrative ones. Agenda will be circulated before meetings, and the minutes afterwards, while officers' foreign trips will require the ECI's approval. It also implicitly admits the flawed implementation of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR). Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) are to launch a "special drive" to enrol anyone "whose name has got left out". But there is no remorse for an exercise that struck lakhs of genuine electors off the rolls in West Bengal and has marauded from State to State. Those deleted are simply asked to reapply as though they were new applicants. There is no answer to Mr. Sandhu's question on who authorised 16.1 lakh appeals to remove voters whom judicial officers had included in West Bengal.

India's institutions have largely held, except in dark periods such as the Emergency, when an executive emboldened by legislative strength ran roughshod over the Constitution and a shamelessly permissive judiciary let it do so via *ADM Jabalpur*. The ECI under Mr. Kumar has overseen the removal of more than 13 crore names from draft rolls through the SIR which, as this daily has repeatedly argued, shifts the onus of enrolment from the state to the elector, deletes names before it verifies and imposes onerous conditions for re-entry. It got away with this because the Supreme Court declined for months to decide whether the exercise was constitutional. When it finally ruled on May 27, the SIR was already a settled fact in Bihar, West Bengal and other Phase 2 States. The judgment, reminiscent of *ADM Jabalpur*'s deference to the state, engaged the SIR in theory and not in practice. It read a provision for exceptional, targeted revisions as a licence for a State-wide sweep. While it assured voters already on the rolls that they were still presumed eligible, the SIR made them prove it all over again. And it brushed aside its 1995 ruling that every removal must be individually reasoned. Events since then indicate the damage done – over nine in 10 appeals decided by West Bengal's tribunals have restored deleted voters months after the Assembly polls; and in one third of Delhi's seats, the draft rolls have fewer electors than those who voted in 2025. The ECI's press note changes very little. The ECI must be reconstituted by a selection committee that does not give the government an overriding majority. Anything less would be a travesty of institutional democracy.

New equilibrium

As the U.S. and China recalibrate ties, implications for other nations are huge

On the surface, Chinese President Xi Jinping's Washington visit appeared to be more about ceremony than substance. President Donald Trump rolled out the red carpet, personally welcoming the Chinese leader at the base where he landed. The last time that a U.S. President accorded such an honour to a foreign leader was when John F. Kennedy welcomed British Prime Minister Harold MacMillan in 1962. Mr. Trump also laid out a grand state dinner at the White House, inviting some of the biggest names in tech and business in the U.S. Beyond the optics, the concrete outcomes from the Trump-Xi talks were modest. The most immediate one was an agreement for both leaders to meet twice this year at the APEC summit in Shenzhen and the G-20 in Miami, marking an unusual four meetings in one year, with Mr. Trump having visited Beijing in May. Both sides also agreed to operationalise a board of trade and investment. No new trade agreement was reached, although both have extended for another two months the trade truce agreed to at Busan last year as well as an arrangement for a \$30 billion reciprocal tariff reduction. China reaffirmed its commitment to buy \$17 billion worth of agricultural products annually, but offered no new ones. Other long pending issues such as semiconductors, rare earths and U.S. arms sales to Taiwan appear deferred for now. Both did, however, announce the establishment of a new dialogue on Artificial Intelligence and the opening of a channel for incidents, amid growing concerns over the consequences of an unregulated AI race.

The modest outcomes from the Xi visit should not obscure the broader shift that recent U.S.-China engagement has underlined. The agreement between the world's two biggest powers to pursue what they call a constructive relationship of strategic stability based on fairness, respect and reciprocity points to a new equilibrium. Their relationship certainly remains beset by serious structural challenges and will remain one marked by rivalry. At the same time, both sides appear eager to set a floor to ensure a rivalry that is more managed, stable and predictable. Countries in the region will be watching closely how this may temper an "America First" Washington's appetite to push back against China in waters far from home. New Delhi will need to carefully watch this evolving new equilibrium. The recent U.S. tariff threats aimed at India have offered a stark contrast to the measured language with which Washington has been engaging Beijing. For long, a strand of Indian strategic thinking has been predicated on the assumption that U.S. strategy in the region was centred on the idea of a relationship with India as a bulwark against Chinese influence. That assumption increasingly appears open to question.

India stands at a critical demographic crossroads. With one of the world's largest youth populations, the country possesses an immense economic advantage. Yet, a youthful population becomes a genuine demographic dividend only when young citizens are educated, skilled, gainfully employed and provided with meaningful opportunities. Otherwise, that demographic promise risks turning into social disillusionment.

China, despite its comparable population, is moving in the opposite demographic direction. Decades of low fertility have accelerated the ageing of its population. India, by contrast, possesses an extraordinary reservoir of young people entering the workforce. The central question is whether the country can create the economic opportunities and infrastructure needed to harness this potential.

The aspiration-reality gap

The smartphone revolution has intensified this challenge. A young person in a town or remote village can now see within seconds how the rest of the world lives, studies, works and travels. Global possibilities are visible on high-definition screens, even as tangible opportunities remain painfully out of reach.

This has created a widening divide between aspiration and reality. The horizons of young Indians have expanded far faster than the institutions and economies around them. Access to higher education has widened, yet meaningful employment opportunities have not kept pace. A college degree is no longer a guarantee of a job, leaving many without financial security or the dignity that comes with economic independence. When heightened aspirations collide with limited opportunities, frustration inevitably follows, often finding expression in protests over recruitment, examination irregularities, examination and test paper leaks, unemployment and systemic failures.

Kashmiri youth share these aspirations but carry a compounding historical burden. Decades of conflict, political uncertainty and economic isolation have deepened their sense of insecurity and constrained their opportunities. Too often, young Kashmiris have been viewed through a narrow security lens, as potential liabilities rather than national assets.

Yet, Jammu and Kashmir, like the rest of India, has a large young population with its own aspirations. Its youth seek the same basic things as young people elsewhere: economic



Mehbooba Mufti

President, Jammu and Kashmir Peoples Democratic Party (PDP)

Reconnecting Kashmir's historic routes could unlock economic opportunities for its youth

independence, dignity, opportunity and a future in which they are not permanently viewed with suspicion.

Jammu and Kashmir possesses an exceptional combination of natural wealth and geographic significance. Its rivers offer substantial hydroelectric potential, its mountains contain valuable mineral resources, and its landscapes sustain a major tourism economy. Yet, its most underutilised strategic asset may be its location.

Focus on Kashmir's historic crossroads

For centuries, Kashmir was never a cul-de-sac. It was a thriving crossroads. Historic caravan routes linked Kashmir and Ladakh with Central Asia, Tibet and the broader Indian subcontinent. These routes carried far more than merchandise. They connected people, ideas, philosophies, literature, cultures and skills. The arrival of Mir Sayyid Ali Hamadani, revered as Shah-i-Hamadan, is deeply embedded in Kashmiri history and is traditionally associated with the arrival of Persian and Central Asian craftsmen who enriched Kashmir's celebrated handicraft traditions. The historical lesson is clear: connectivity creates economic ecosystems.

Today, Indian strategic thinking needs to look beyond the immediate constraints posed by the Line of Control with Pakistan and the Line of Actual Control with China. Where political and security conditions permit, India needs a pragmatic framework to gradually restore Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh to the role they historically occupied: that of a bridge connecting South Asia with Central Asia and the wider Eurasian landmass.

For this, India needs a diplomatic road map alongside its infrastructure road map. Reopening traditional routes towards Pakistan or Central Asia cannot happen without sustained engagement with neighbouring countries. With Pakistan, the objective should be to explore confidence-building measures and trade connectivity wherever feasible. With China, India should pursue practical dialogue on trans-Himalayan connectivity wherever economic interests and security concerns can be reconciled.

This transition could begin with a phased connectivity strategy. India should identify historically important trade corridors that could eventually be revived as modern economic corridors, beginning with those where security and diplomatic conditions are most conducive. This does not mean opening every route at once.

The paradox of de-Sinification in global production

SpaceX's reported efforts, in July 2026, to remove Chinese-made components from its supply chain capture a new phase in the restructuring of global production. The challenge is no longer simply where a product is assembled. It is increasingly about what lies several layers beneath the final manufacturer – and whether firms can identify, replace and verify suppliers embedded deep within complex production networks. Moving a factory may be relatively straightforward; removing an industrial ecosystem from the production process is not.

The other side of de-Sinification

Here lies a less noticed paradox. The ecosystem problem is not confined to foreign firms seeking to reduce their exposure to China. Chinese companies expanding overseas increasingly confront it from the opposite direction. While foreign firms struggle to disentangle themselves from Chinese suppliers and capabilities, Chinese firms must decide how much of the industrial ecosystem that supports their competitiveness at home can be carried abroad and how much must be recreated locally.

This difficulty is compounded by the fact that China's industrial ecosystem is not standing still. Even as foreign firms seek to reduce their dependence on China, China is building capabilities in areas where it has historically relied heavily on foreign technology. Memory-chip maker CXMT is illustrative. It has emerged as the world's fourth-largest producer of DRAM chips, although it continues to trail global leaders in advanced memory technologies and remains dependent on access to foreign chipmaking equipment. Attempts to reduce exposure to China are therefore taking place against a moving target: Chinese firms are simultaneously working to reduce their own external dependencies.

The reverse challenge becomes visible when Chinese manufacturers venture overseas. They too confront a form of de-Sinification, although from the opposite direction. Their internationalisation increasingly involves more than establishing final-assembly plants. The



G. Venkat Raman

Professor, Humanities and Social Sciences, Indian Institute of Management, Indore, Madhya Pradesh

De-Sinification is reshaping factories, but industrial ecosystems remain harder to move

competitiveness of companies such as BYD and Xpeng rests partly on dense networks of component makers, engineering capabilities and production relationships developed within China. Moving a factory abroad therefore creates a choice: take existing suppliers along, cultivate new local suppliers, or combine the two. Each route carries different costs – and produces a different degree of genuine localisation.

The challenge beyond factories

BYD's expansion in Europe illustrates one response. As it builds manufacturing capacity in Hungary, the company is also developing relationships with European suppliers. Xpeng has chosen another route, contracting Canadian automotive supplier Magna to assemble its vehicles in Austria. The two approaches differ, but they expose the same underlying problem: producing outside China is easier than reproducing outside China, the ecosystem that made production in China efficient in the first place.

What makes these ecosystems difficult to unwind or reproduce is that they consist of more than identifiable suppliers. They embody accumulated relationships between firms, specialised skills, tooling and production knowledge, logistics networks, and the ability of suppliers to respond quickly when designs or production volumes change. Many of these advantages are built through repeated interaction rather than formal contracts. This is why replacing an individual Chinese supplier does not necessarily eliminate dependence on the wider Chinese production system – and why transplanting a Chinese factory abroad does not automatically transplant the capabilities surrounding it.

Seen from this perspective, de-Sinification has a less obvious, two-sided character. Foreign firms attempting to reduce their exposure to China confront the depth of China's integration into their production networks. Chinese firms going global confront the difficulty of reproducing abroad the ecosystem on which their competitiveness depends. One side is trying to

Pilot corridors could be developed and expanded progressively on the basis of experience.

Security cannot be ignored in any such endeavour. But security and connectivity need not automatically be treated as opposing objectives. Properly regulated connectivity can create greater economic interdependence and potentially provide stronger incentives for stability.

The same principle should guide India's approach to Central Asia. Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh could become India's northern economic gateway, giving Indian businesses greater access to Central Asian markets while bringing investment, tourism and commerce to the region. The benefits would extend far beyond Kashmir.

A road to opportunity

A functioning land corridor creates opportunities at every stage, from construction, transport and warehousing to hospitality, manufacturing, agriculture, logistics, finance, technology and services. Unlike air connectivity, whose economic benefits are concentrated around a limited number of nodes, a trade corridor can generate economic activity across a wider geography through which it passes.

Most importantly, it could give the young people of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh something far more valuable than another promise. It could give them wings to fly towards new horizons.

India's demographic advantage is a window of opportunity, not a permanent condition. We cannot afford to allow a generation to grow up watching possibilities on smartphones while encountering closed doors in the real world.

For Jammu and Kashmir, the answer may lie partly in reopening doors that history once kept open. The Silk Road was never only about silk. It was about the movement of goods, people, ideas and possibilities.

It is time to view Kashmir not merely through the prism of conflict, but through the lens of enterprise, connectivity and integration. Former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee spoke of abandoning beaten paths and searching for new ways to address difficult issues. The ancient roads across the Himalayas do not belong merely in history books. Reimagined as modern economic arteries, they could become pathways to opportunity, giving the next generation not another reason to wait, but a road towards a better future.

disentangle itself from an ecosystem; the other is trying to make that ecosystem portable. Both discover that changing the location of production is easier than changing the capabilities and relationships that sustain it.

What India needs to note, must build

This distinction matters particularly for India. The reorganisation of production is already creating openings. Japan's TDK has expanded its battery production in Haryana, deepening an Indian manufacturing base that it has been developing as part of its broader China-plus-one strategy. Murata Manufacturing, another Japanese electronic-component maker, is expanding its manufacturing presence in India. These investments show that India is beginning to receive parts of production ecosystems previously concentrated in China. But making the most of this opening requires more than attracting individual factories. India needs domestic suppliers capable of meeting demanding cost, quality and delivery standards, alongside reliable logistics, skilled workers and access to critical inputs. The test is whether new investments progressively deepen linkages with Indian firms and bring specialised capabilities and intermediate production into the domestic economy. The same principle should inform Chinese investment: its value should be judged partly by the capabilities and supplier networks it develops locally. India's opportunity is to convert the movement of factories into the gradual accumulation of an industrial ecosystem of its own.

The emerging geography of global production will therefore be shaped by more than decisions over where to locate factories. It will depend on whether the ecosystems behind those factories can be dismantled, transferred or rebuilt. De-Sinification may be visible in new factory locations and investment announcements, but its real test lies deeper within the production system. Factories can cross borders relatively quickly; industrial ecosystems, built through accumulated capabilities and relationships, are far less mobile.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A credibility crisis

The Election Commission of India (ECI)'s decision to undertake a special drive to help those left out of the SIR and make changes in its functioning is clearly a response to the investigation by The Indian Express and the brickbats that followed from the Opposition. But it would be premature to see this as a change of heart. The ECI's handling of various issues so far has raised serious

questions about its independence and sensitivity to public concerns. As a constitutional body, it was expected to function with the fierce independence seen during T.N. Seshan's tenure. Instead, a widespread perception prevails that it has become vulnerable to political pressures. As a septuagenarian voter who values honesty and sincerity, I find it deeply

troubling that such independent institutions respond more to those in power than to the Constitution, their conscience and the collective will of the citizens.

V. Nagarajan,
Chennai

The reported dissent of two Election Commissioners over the functioning of the electoral-roll revision process raises serious

questions about the working of the electoral machinery. Concerns over ERONet access, changes to Form 6 and the exclusion of eligible voters cannot be treated lightly. Yet, recording dissent alone cannot end the responsibility of constitutional functionaries. If such irregularities were considered serious, the Commissioners ought to have pursued the available institutional mechanisms to

seek their resolution. Their failure to do so also raises questions about accountability within the institution entrusted with protecting the integrity of the electoral process.

Kanhaiya Pandey,
Girdih, Jharkhand

The exposure of 14 instances of objections to unilateral decisions concerning electoral rolls points to an assault on our democracy. However, a

bureaucrat does not weaponise a constitutional body in a vacuum. There appears to be a conspiracy to engineer poll outcomes from behind the scenes. If constitutional institutions are compromised, those responsible must face legal consequences to restore trust.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The pitfalls of mandatory FIRs

On August 5, the Supreme Court, in *G. Ganesh v. State of Tamil Nadu and Others*, reiterated that the police must register an FIR upon receiving any information about a missing ‘person’. The court clarified that the expression ‘person’ did not refer only to missing children but included every person.

The Supreme Court in May issued certain directions which inter alia included setting up a special portal by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) dedicated to human trafficking, registration of an FIR without waiting for any preliminary enquiry or leaving it to the guardians or family of the missing person to first search for him/her, activating the anti-human trafficking units (AHTUs) of districts, restoring the recovered child to the rightful guardian in accordance with law and Aadhaar verification or issuance of an Aadhaar card.

Presumption for children

The directions issued in *G. Ganesh* are no different from the directions issued by the Supreme Court in *Bachpan Bachao Andolan (BBA) versus Union of India and Others* in January 2013, in which the court was dealing only with ‘missing children’. The court then issued two directions. The first related to mandatory recording of FIR so that police authorities are activated in taking steps to trace the child. Second, the court asked each State to set up a Special Juvenile Police Unit at every police station in accordance with the provisions of the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Rules, 2007.

In May 2013, when Madhya Pradesh expressed



RK Vij

is a former IPS officer

some doubt with respect to the provisions of Section 154 CrPC (now Section 173 BNSS), which relates to information in cognisable cases, the court said that there will be an initial presumption of either abduction or trafficking, unless, in the investigation, the same is proved otherwise.

Second, at least one specially trained police officer at each police station was directed to be designated as a Juvenile Welfare Officer as per Section 63 of the JJ Act, 2000. In case a missing child is not recovered within four months from the date of the FIR, the matter is to be forwarded to the AHTU.

While, in the case of a missing child, the presumption of a cognisable offence to set the law in motion is understandable, as a child’s consent has no relevance in law, such a presumption may be problematic when an adult leaves the house of his or her own volition.

Adults have agency

It is a matter of common knowledge that many adults leave their homes to live together as partners or get married without the consent of their parents. But in some cases, couples have been killed (in the name of family honour) after being found, with or without the assistance of the police.

It is also undisputed that initially every such case is reported as a missing-person case. If an FIR is registered in every case, it will become the duty of the police to trace such couples or an adult and hand them over to their parents. A person may leave information indicating his or her willingness before leaving, but the police would

still trace them to verify it. Thus, consenting couples may still face unnecessary police investigation.

The case of *G. Ganesh* involved a one-year-and-10-month-old child who went missing from Chennai in 2011, following which a ‘child missing’ case was registered. The case was transferred first to the Central Crime Branch and then to a Special Investigation Team, but the child remained untraced for 14 years. The petitioner alleged that the MHA guidelines issued in June 2013 for missing children were not followed and that the case was not transferred to the AHTU after four months. The Madras High Court dismissed the petition in March 2025, holding that the police had made all efforts to trace the child and that the 2013 guidelines were not applicable in 2011.

There was no occasion for the Supreme Court to *suo motu* take up the issue of missing adults. The May judgment also does not indicate that the States were heard on the issue. While the court’s intention to deal firmly with human trafficking cannot be doubted, not allowing even a small window for the police to conduct a preliminary enquiry is difficult to fathom. A week or fortnight could allow the police to filter cases where there is credible information that the person reported missing was neither abducted nor trafficked. A blanket presumption of kidnapping or trafficking in every case of a missing adult, without any evidence, is against the spirit of the statute. To that extent, the court needs to review its direction mandating the registration of an FIR.

Form 26 and the statutory mandate

On June 12, the Supreme Court dismissed the petition filed by Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan challenging the Returning Officer’s decision, rejecting her nomination for the Rajya Sabha election from Madhya Pradesh. The Returning Officer held that Natarajan had failed to disclose, in her Form 26 affidavit, a pending criminal complaint against her and had thereby suppressed material information.

The criminal complaint, instituted in 2025, alleged that Natarajan failed to take appropriate action against a party leader accused of misconduct. The case raises important questions about the scope of the disclosure obligations imposed on electoral candidates and the constitutional remedies available when nomination papers are rejected.

History of legislation

The statutory obligation requiring electoral candidates to disclose their criminal antecedents is of relatively recent origin. Parliament in 2002 inserted Section 33-A into the Representation of the People Act, 1951, or ROPA. The legislative amendment was prompted by the top court’s landmark decision in *Union of India v. Association for Democratic Reforms* (2002), where the court held that mandatory disclosure neither imposed an additional qualification for contesting elections nor conflicted with the scheme of the ROPA. Rather, it advanced the electorate’s right to make an informed choice and strengthened the purity of the electoral process.

Pursuant to the judgment, the Election



Vanshaj Azad

is an advocate based in New Delhi. Presently, he is working as a Law Clerk-cum-Research Associate at the Supreme Court of India

Commission was directed to mandate disclosure of specified criminal antecedents, assets, liabilities and educational qualifications through an affidavit. The government subsequently introduced Sections 33-A, 33-B, 75-A and 125-A into ROPA and amended the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, prescribing Form 26 as the affidavit to accompany every nomination paper.

Form 26 was initially aligned with Section 33-A; a significant departure occurred in 2018. Paragraph 5 of the Form was amended to require disclosure of all pending criminal cases, whereas Section 33-A mandates disclosure only of those cases involving offences punishable with imprisonment of two years or more in which charges have already been framed by a competent court.

It is this apparent divergence between the parent statute and delegated legislation that lies at the heart of the present controversy.

Disclosure mandate

The disclosure requirement is operationalised through Rule 4A of the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, which requires every candidate to file an affidavit in Form 26 along with the nomination papers. Rule 4A, however, is merely a procedural mechanism for implementing Section 33A and thus, it cannot become an independent source of substantive obligations. Yet, the 2018 amendment to Form 26 appears to do precisely that. Paragraph 5 now requires disclosure of all pending criminal cases, regardless of whether charges have been framed. The constitutional

question, therefore, extends beyond Natarajan’s candidature. Can delegated legislation, under the guise of prescribing the manner of disclosure, enlarge a substantive statutory obligation?

Constitutional remedies

While describing Article 32, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar famously called it the “heart and soul” of the Constitution. However, while dismissing Natarajan’s challenge to the rejection of her nomination, the top court relied upon the Constitution Bench decision in *N.P. Ponnuswami v. Returning Officer* (1952), which held that Article 329(b) bars judicial intervention in electoral disputes once the election process has commenced, leaving an election petition as the exclusive post-election remedy.

Natarajan’s case exposes the limits of that doctrine. Should the constitutional remedies under Articles 32 and 226 remain unavailable even where the Returning Officer’s decision is alleged to be manifestly arbitrary or patently without jurisdiction? Ponnuswami’s rationale was to prevent judicial intervention from interrupting the electoral process, not to insulate totally perverse administrative decisions.

Although Natarajan has been granted liberty to challenge her rejection through an election petition under Section 100 of ROPA, the broader constitutional question survives. It may be time for the Supreme Court to revisit *Ponnuswami* and clarify whether constitutional courts should remain powerless even in the face of patent arbitrariness during the electoral process.

Long wait for justice as pendencies in rape cases mount

Rape cases have remained steady since 2018, but pendency has grown, with less than 2% ending in conviction in the same year as the trial

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy

The gang-rape of a 17-year-old girl on September 21 by three men who posed as police personnel at Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir in South-east Delhi and social media videos from Bihar’s Jamui and Samastipur showing harassment of girls, have once again raised concerns about women’s safety in public spaces and the need for prompt and stringent preventive and punitive measures.

Legislative changes over the years, especially since the 2012 Nirbhaya rape case in Delhi, have introduced tougher punishments and set timelines for disposal of rape cases.

However, an analysis of rape cases from the reports of the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) shows that the country still has a long way to go in ensuring justice in a time-bound manner. (This analysis does not include rape cases filed under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, which are reported separately by the NCRB).

The country’s conviction rate of less than 30% of rape cases is already low, and analysis showed that even for those cases that result in conviction, the wait is usually long.

Chart 1 shows the number of cases of rape registered every year since 2018. This translates to an average of 84 cases per day and nearly three cases per hour.

Further data show that roughly 2% of the cases that were sent to trial ended in conviction within the same year.

This is quite low even if one were to assume that the cases that went to trial towards the end of the year could spill over to the subsequent year despite following legally mandated deadlines.

Though the number of new cases has fairly remained the same,

the pendency in the courts has consistently grown over the years, as shown in **Chart 2**.

Chart 3 illustrates how only a small fraction of cases entering the system result in conviction after trial within the same year. The chart shows data for 2024, the latest year for which the NCRB has released the data.

Nearly 40,000 cases were taken up for investigation in 2024, which included the 29,536 rape cases reported that year. The rest were predominantly cases pending from the previous year and a handful of cases that were reopened.

Of these cases in the investigation pool, about 25,000 (63%) were chargesheeted, while the rest ended up in the categories of pending police investigation, transfer of the case to another investigative agency, or disposal by the police if they found that the investigation did not warrant further proceedings.

Trial backlog

When the chargesheeted cases went to trial, they added to the lakhs of cases that were already in the trial backlog, bringing the total rape cases in the trial pool to 2,06,777 cases. Nearly 90% of these remained pending at the end of the year.

Of the rest of the 20,587 cases disposed of by the judiciary, nearly 68% were acquittals, 8% were discharged, and the remaining 24% ended up in convictions.

Only 421 of those cases resulted in convictions – which is just 2% of those taken up for trial that year and less than 1.5% of the total rape cases filed that year.

A look at the previous years also revealed similar patterns.

In 2023, only 2.3% of cases that went to trial ended up in conviction, while these figures for 2022 and 2021 respectively were 1.9% and 1.2%, which emphasise the need for additional measures beyond the legislative amendments to ensure time-bound delivery of justice.

Elusive justice

The data for the charts were sourced from National Crime Records Bureau’s annual Crime In India reports



Demanding safety: A college student holds a placard during a solidarity march demanding police action and better safety for women following the alleged gang-rape of a girl, in New Delhi, on September 23. REUTERS

CHART 1: Nearly 30,000 cases of rape were reported in India since 2018, averaging to around 80 rape cases a day

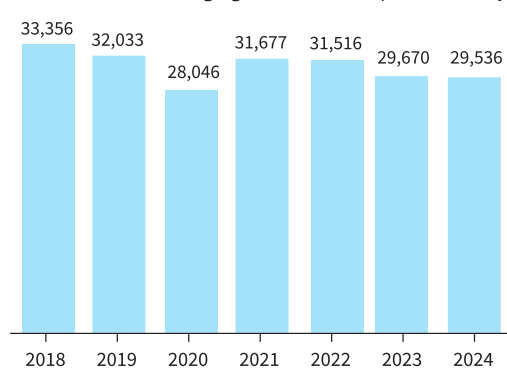


CHART 2: Status of rape cases that went to trial at the end of each year. Values above bars are cases pending trial

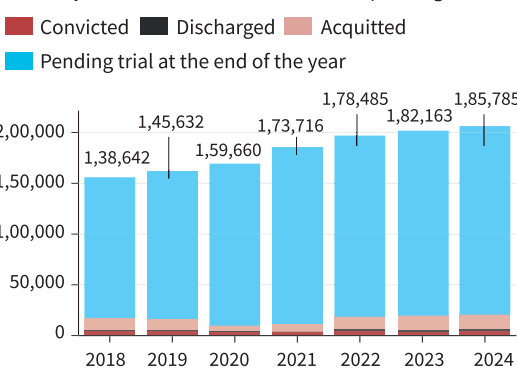
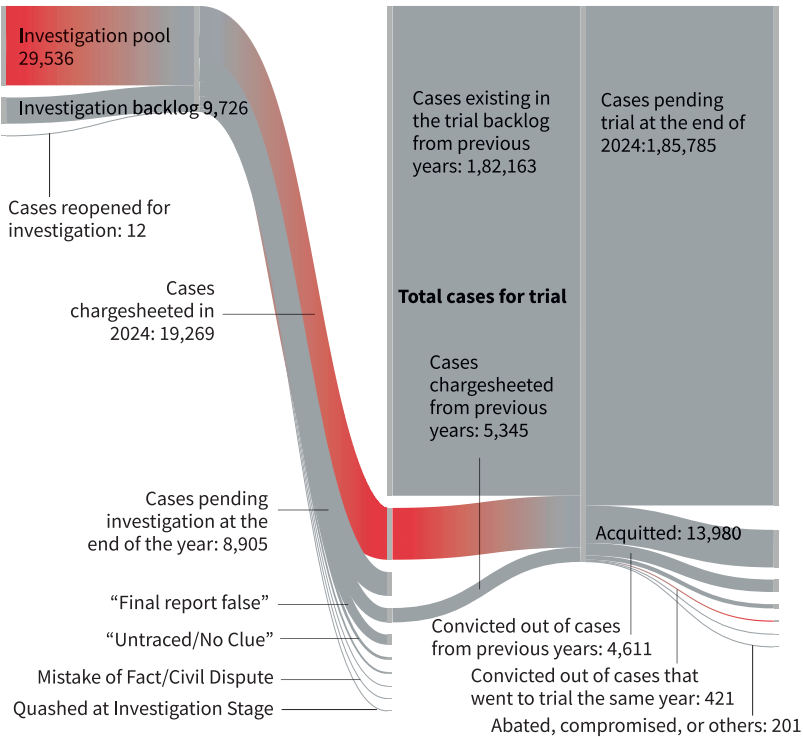
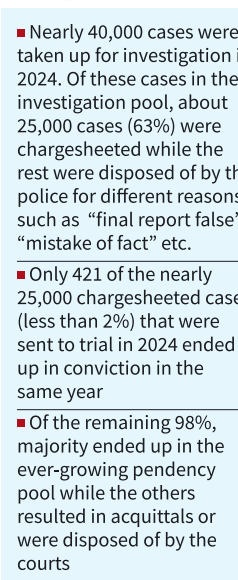


CHART 3: This shows how rape cases investigated in 2024 moved from the police to the judiciary, with many adding to the pendency backlog



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 28, 1976

Electricity from Hotwater Springs

Manikaran (Kulu), Sept. 27: Hotwater springs that local people bathe and wash in and use to cook food might one day help light up their homes. “We are looking for steam in the area”, says Mr. Zahir Alam, Chief of the drilling operations of the Geological Survey of India project at Manikaran.

“Once we hit steam, it can be harnessed to produce electricity”.

The geo-thermal project has been under way for over a year now and the workers have bored about a dozen holes, up to 200 metres deep, in Manikaran and neighbouring Rasoi, but with little luck. Researchers in snow-laden areas of Ladakh have been able to grow cauliflower and strawberries by using heat from these springs to maintain optimal temperature in hothouses, known as greenhouses.

Elsewhere, they have been used in place of electricity to operate refrigeration plants.

Scientists offer four possible explanations for the age-old natural phenomenon: underground radioactivity, some strong chemical reaction, movement of the earth’s crust, or the water coming into contact with magma – red-hot rocks in the earth’s womb.

But the local people have another tale handed down to them over the centuries.

Lord Shiva’s consort, Parvati, once, it seems, dropped a necklace bead into a pond, where the serpent god, Vasuki, gulped it. Shiva naturally asked Vasuki to return the ornament, and when the latter refused, the Lord glared at the pond in such rage that the water in it began to boil. Poor Vasuki quickly turned over the bead. He was perhaps spared further agony, but the water in the area is still bubbling. Hot springs burst forth almost wherever one digs.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 28, 1926

Rs. Two for a copper

Colombo, Sept. 27: An amazing story gained considerable credence in Colombo to-day that the Treasury was offering two rupees for every cent bearing 1924 date. It was believed that in making cents at the mint, a quantity of gold was mixed with copper. Many people called demanding rupees two. The story was circulated either as legpull or for the purpose of getting money from credulous persons. Some boutique keepers made a profit in selling 1924 cents.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people rescued during floods in Chhattisgarh

5,000 Nearly 5,000 people were rescued in the last two days after heavy rains swelled rivers in Chhattisgarh, officials said on Sunday. The administration has set up 43 relief camps in urban and rural areas of the Bastar district. The Indravati river level rose to 12.56 metres by 8 p.m. on Saturday, 4.26 metres above the danger mark. PTI

People who died in separate mass shootings in S. Africa

27 The first massacre occurred late Saturday night near Johannesburg. The second happened in the early hours of Sunday near Cape Town. No arrests had been made in the two shootings, which came just five days after another mass shooting near the city of Durban killed at least 11 people. Shootings are the most common form of homicide in South Africa. PTI

Palestinians killed by Israel in Gaza since October 2023

74,016 While a ceasefire that took effect on October 10 last year has halted the heaviest fighting, Israeli strikes have continued in what the military described as responses to threats or attacks. Since the ceasefire, 1,145 Palestinians have been killed, said the Ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led government. PTI

Missing trainee teachers honoured by protesters in Mexico

43 Thousands of protesters wore red and carried symbolic coffins at a demonstration in Mexico City on Saturday, demanding answers about the 43 trainee teachers who went missing 12 years ago. Prosecutors initially said officers delivered the teacher trainees to drug cartel hitmen, who killed them. Independent human rights experts have rejected the conclusion. AFP

People rescued from child trafficking racket in Arunachal Pradesh

51 According to Namsai Superintendent of Police Sange Thinley, sustained investigation and coordinated operations led to a significant jump in rescued children from 19 during the initial phase to 51, including four adults. During the initial crackdown, the police rescued 19 children, most of them below eight years of age. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Should voting be a fundamental right?

A recent *Indian Express* report revealed an unprecedented rift within the EC over alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, prompting a re-examination of the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one

LETTER & SPIRIT

Kartikey Singh

On September 23, an *Indian Express* investigation revealed an unprecedented rift within the three-member Election Commission of India (EC), with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recording 14 objections over 10 months against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, regarding alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, without the Commission’s full approval.

The report also found that 97 eligible voters from Goa were excluded from the electoral roll after the centralised ECINet software prevented ground-level Electoral Registration Officers (ERO) from reversing decisions. More concerning, the consequences extend beyond the loss of voting rights. Reportedly, several State schemes use electoral rolls to establish eligibility, including the Goa Mediclaim Scheme. The scheme covers super-speciality treatments unavailable in government hospitals, such as dialysis, angioplasty, open-heart surgery, transplants, chemotherapy and cochlear implants, and is available only to State voters. This issue has once again cast a spotlight on the ‘right to vote’, the foundational processes of India’s electoral machinery, and the genesis of India’s ‘universal adult suffrage’ (UAS).

What shaped adult suffrage in India? India’s constitutional promise of the ‘right to vote’ differs significantly from that of many Western democracies. Reflecting the flawed belief, espoused by thinkers like J.S. Mill, that voting should be reserved for the “enlightened”, countries like the U.K. initially restricted the franchise to male property owners. Universal male suffrage emerged only in 1918, and women were granted the ‘right to vote’ a decade later in 1928. In the U.S., although the 15th and 19th Amendments extended voting rights to African Americans (1870) and women (1920), systemic barriers such as poll taxes and literacy tests continued to disenfranchise many for decades thereafter.

In sharp contrast, India’s choice of immediate, universal inclusion ensured ‘democratic equality’ from the outset, bypassing the prolonged and often violent struggles seen elsewhere. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’, regardless of gender, caste, religion, education, or property. This commitment to a robust, inclusive democracy found further constitutional reinforcement in a series of Supreme Court judgments, notably starting with *Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala* (1973), which established democracy as part of the ‘basic structure’ doctrine. For this ideal to function meaningfully, people should be able to freely decide the fate of their government.

This inclusive vision was operationalised through two key laws: the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which governs the preparation and revision of electoral rolls; and the 1951 Act, which regulates election conduct, candidature, and electoral offences. The EC has repeatedly introduced administrative innovations to realise this ‘constitutional promise’.

Notably, the then Chief Election Commissioner Sukumar Sen, faced with the task of enrolling 173 million largely illiterate voters, turned a logistical hurdle into a democratic breakthrough by



Enabling democracy: Courts have regarded the right to vote as an inseparable part of democracy, as it enables citizens to shape governance. R. ASHOK

introducing election symbols, making UAS practically accessible.

In India, the EC has the responsibility to reach the last citizen, wherever they may be, to actualise their ‘right to elect’.

What is the legal status of right to vote?

The legal status of the ‘right to vote’ in India has long been debated, and whether it is classified as a statutory, constitutional, or fundamental right determines how easily it can be changed, how it is enforced, and the level of legal protection it receives. Although Dr. B.R. Ambedkar and K.T. Shah proposed including it in the Constitution’s fundamental rights part, the Constituent Assembly’s Advisory Committee ultimately rejected the idea. Importantly, a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in *Kuldip Nayar v. Union of India* (2006) held that the ‘right to elect’ is a statutory right under Section 62 of the RPA, 1951, and not a fundamental or constitutional right.

Though a two-judge Bench in *Rajbala v. State of Haryana* described the ‘right to vote’ as a constitutional right in 2015, the larger bench ruling in *Kuldip Nayar* prevails. Again, in *Anoop Baranwal v. Union of India* (2023), the top court declined to pronounce on the issue, noting that it had already been settled by the five-judge Bench in the *Kuldip Nayar* judgment. However, in his dissent, Justice Ajay Rastogi asserted that the ‘right to vote’ is an expression of Article 19(1)(a) and reflects the essence of Article 21. Yet, as this view remains a minority opinion, the ‘right to elect’ continues to be recognised as a statutory right.

Nevertheless, even though it is not a fundamental right, courts have regarded the ‘right to vote’ as an inseparable part of democracy, anchoring their reasoning in the idea that it enables citizens to shape governance, making it a “democratic imperative” vital to the Indian republic’s survival.

Why do we need accurate poll rolls?

Free and fair elections rest on accurate electoral rolls under the RPA, 1950. Inaccuracies – such as mass omissions, ineligible inclusions, duplicates, or incorrect entries – undermine the “one person, one vote” principle by enabling impersonation, disenfranchisement, or

dilution of votes, ultimately distorting the people’s mandate. Therefore, the EC is empowered under Section 21 of the 1950 Act to prepare and revise these rolls to ensure integrity. The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 lays down how the EC must transact its business. Section 17 requires the Commission’s business to be conducted in accordance with the Act, while Section 18 provides that its procedure and allocation of business may be regulated by unanimous decision. It further requires business to be transacted as far as possible unanimously, but where the CEC and other Commissioners differ, the matter is decided by majority.

Deriving its authority from Article 324, the EC serves as the constitutional guardian of elections, with powers of superintendence, direction, and control. A key duty is preparing accurate electoral rolls, guided by Section 19 of the RPA, 1950, which mandates that any citizen aged 18 or above, “ordinarily resident” in a constituency and not disqualified, is entitled to be registered. “Ordinary resident” implies a genuine, continuous presence, not a temporary stay.

While discrepancies may arise, courts have consistently held that only substantial and systemic errors that demonstrably “materially affected” the election outcome can compromise the sanctity of the electoral roll. Minor mistakes or isolated disenfranchisement are insufficient.

Yet the recent Goa episode complicates this comfortable “substantial versus isolated” binary that courts have relied on. The *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters were dropped from the rolls, not through electoral fraud but because the ECINet software architecture itself denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. What makes the episode damning is not merely the exclusion, but the apparent unresponsiveness that followed. The EROs reportedly flagged the anomalies to the Commission by email, yet the corrections were not restored. This is not the isolated clerical error that courts have historically forgiven; it is a systemic failure baked into the software’s design, compounded by administrative inertia.

While the right to inclusion or

objection in electoral rolls is conferred on individuals, not political parties, the court in *Lakshmi Charan Sen v. A.K.M. Hassan Uzzaman* (1985) observed that in a largely illiterate and politically unaware electorate, parties should take steps to ensure eligible voters are included, and ineligible ones are removed. Given India’s party-based Parliamentary system, such vigilance will help in preserving ‘electoral integrity’.

What lies ahead?

The revelations against the EC lend fresh urgency to the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one. If the body constitutionally tasked with safeguarding the franchise can itself be riven by disputes over unilateral action, leaving the citizen’s only recourse to the EC’s internal correction mechanisms, or to a statutory right that the Parliament could dilute at will, is precarious.

Many scholars argue that the ‘right to vote’ cannot be regarded as merely a statutory right, as it flows from Article 326, and any legislation regulating it must conform to the parameters prescribed by Articles 325 and 326. It is therefore necessary to ensure that the legislature does not impose irrational or unreasonable restrictions on the ‘right to vote’, particularly since “free and fair elections” and “democracy” are basic features of the Constitution.

Justice Rastogi’s dissent in *Anoop Baranwal*, over the legal status of the ‘right to vote’, offers doctrinal ground for a larger Bench to revisit the question that the majority in *Kuldip Nayar* considered settled.

Elevating the ‘right to vote’ to fundamental status would not diminish the EC’s authority to purify rolls; it would instead subject that authority to the heightened standard of judicial review reserved for fundamental rights, ensuring that the drive to centralise electoral administration is always weighed against, rather than allowed to override, the citizen’s claim to be counted. In a democracy where software now mediates the relationship between the voter and the ballot, the constitutional status of the ‘right to vote’ can no longer remain a matter of legislative grace. (*Kartikey Singh is a lawyer based in New Delhi.*)

THE GIST

India’s choice of immediate, universal adult suffrage ensured democratic equality from the outset. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’

An *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters from Goa were dropped from the rolls because the ECINet software denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. This is not an isolated clerical error, but a systemic failure, compounded by administrative inertia

If the body constitutionally tasked with safeguarding the voting rights can be riven by disputes over unilateral action, leaving the citizen’s only recourse to the EC’s internal correction mechanisms, or to a statutory right that the Parliament could dilute at will is precarious

CACHE



Expanding dragnet: ICE has received billions of dollars in funding during U.S. President Donald Trump's second term, and dramatically ramped up its presence. REUTERS

How Big Tech companies contribute to anti-immigration crackdowns

As the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) increases its presence, Big Tech firms are facing both internal and external pressure to take a stronger stance against the controversial agency

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far:

On September 15, a small group of protesters assembled near San Francisco's Moscone Center, the venue for Salesforce's annual tech event, calling for an end to any and all contracts between the company and the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), as thousands of attendees passed by them to watch CEO Marc Benioff's keynote. Though Big Tech firms have long sought out U.S. government contracts, specific links to ICE are now sparking employee discomfort, customer protests, and calls for boycotts.

What is ICE and why is it controversial?

ICE was established as a federal law enforcement agency, with a mission to protect the U.S. from cross-border crime and illegal immigration, after the country witnessed the heinous terrorist attacks on September 11, 2001.

The agency has received billions of dollars in funding during U.S. President Donald Trump's second term, and dramatically ramped up its presence. Arrests have spiked, along with the use of violence against citizens.

Untoward law enforcement incidents in Minneapolis are a case in point. In January, writer and mother Renée Good, 37, was killed by a federal immigration officer in the city. Days later, nurse Alex Pretti, 37, was killed by Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials while intervening in an ICE operation. Even though there have been reports of multiple detained foreigners dying in ICE custody, the killings of two American

citizens triggered bipartisan outrage and protests.

ICE says that it "does not detain unaccompanied children – except in rare instances." But a report by the *New York Times* in February revealed that the agency was detaining hundreds of children. Another report by *Marshall Project*, a not-for-profit news organisation, said that over 6,200 children were detained by ICE during Mr. Trump's second term.

Does U.S. Big Tech work with ICE?

Large tech companies often seek high-profile government contracts with federal agencies as they provide regular revenue streams and boost their reputation. The partnerships range from allowing advertisements for the agency's recruitment efforts to directly fulfilling ICE's online and offline needs.

But tech firms are divided in how they support ICE. While defence-focused data analytics firm Palantir is proud of its business relationship with ICE, customer relationship management tech firm Salesforce has adopted a more cautious and centrist approach.

Palantir's contract with the U.S. government began under the Obama administration in 2011, and has continued through four administrations.

"Palantir is enabling ICE to utilise our platform to better track the immigration lifecycle and serve our national security while promoting efficiency, transparency, and accountability. By improving data integration and data-dependent workflows, our software can help ICE more effectively and reliably perform its core functions," Palantir said in a blog post.

Salesforce, on the other hand, per CEO

Marc Benioff's Dreamforce keynote, said that all 50 U.S. States and 15 cabinet agencies use the company's service.

Salesforce's arrangement with federal agencies has been a cause of concern for its employees since 2018, according to several media reports. More recently, in February, over 1,400 Salesforce employees wrote a letter calling on Mr. Benioff to stop promoting Salesforce AI contracts to ICE, and to push back against the rising presence of ICE agents in the U.S. "We are deeply troubled by recent press reports describing Salesforce pitches of AI technology to U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) to help the agency 'expeditiously' hire 10,000 new agents and vet tip-line reports," stated the employees' letter, as reported by *CNBC*.

Mr. Benioff had also previously cracked a joke about ICE agents tracking foreign employees during a company event, as per a *404 Media* report.

Robin Washington, Salesforce's President and Chief Operating and Financial Officer, stressed that the company valued equality and trust, in response to *The Hindu's* questions on anti-ICE protesters.

"I think anytime you attract 50,000 people, to Salesforce, you're going to have people that come with different perspectives and viewpoints. Our goal here is to put on a very future-forward opportunity for people to understand our vision, which is 'AI meets the number one AI CRM' [Customer Relationship Management] and we hope that everyone will participate and learn from that, whether they're a protestor or a stakeholder, you know – we try to create an environment where it's safe for everyone to come and bring their voice,"

Ms. Washington told *The Hindu*.

She explained that Salesforce had multiple vehicles through which leadership could engage directly with employees who had different perspectives.

Are tech boycotts effective?

Immigrant advocacy platforms have called for boycotts against tech companies including Amazon and Microsoft for allegedly providing cloud services to ICE. Boycott calls have targeted Apple for removing anti-ICE apps, as well as Google, LinkedIn, Meta, Spotify, and YouTube for allegedly running ICE-related recruitment ads on their platforms. Other tech companies on boycott lists include AT&T, Comcast, Dell, Clearview AI, IBM, and X.

Non-technology companies have also faced flak for feeding and housing ICE agents, apart from helping them operate charter flights and private prisons. However, the sheer number of companies with both direct and indirect ICE links complicates boycott efforts. Even so, the public reporting surrounding ICE spending means that everyday citizens can access the facts that they need to hold their local companies accountable.

"Salesforce has a history of showing up for our communities. As a Bay Area tech leader, Salesforce has an opportunity to use its influence to defend democracy, refuse to profit from family separation, [and] to push the tech industry to follow," stated part of a flyer that protesters handed out to *The Hindu* on the first day of the Dreamforce event.

This month, the *NBC* news outlet cited a senior U.S. official to report that ICE agents arrested around 50,000 people in August.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test your knowledge of the life and career of legendary singer Lata Mangeshkar on her 97th birth anniversary

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1

What was her birth name before her parents renamed her after a character (Latika) from one of her father's plays?

QUESTION 2

What is the significance of the song *Paa Lagoon Kar Jori* for the 1946 film *Aap Ki Sewa Mein*?

QUESTION 3

Name the music director who backed her, after she was rejected for a having a 'thin voice', famously remarking that filmmakers would "fall at her feet" to get her to sing?

QUESTION 4

What is common to the songs: *Beeti*

Na Bitai Raina (Parichay), *Roothi Roothi Piya (Kora Kaagaz)* and *Yaara Seeli Seeli (Lekin)*?

QUESTION 5

Under what name did she compose music for Marathi films in the 1960s?

QUESTION 6

Name the Lata rendition penned by Kavi Pradeep and composed by C. Ramachandra that brought PM Jawaharlal Nehru to tears in 1963.

QUESTION 7

She sang the thumri *Kanha Main Tose Hari* for the only Hindi film of which celebrated director who also composed the music?

QUESTION 8

In which year was she awarded the Bharat Ratna?



Visual question: In which city is this installation located at a place named 'Lata Chowk'? SANDEEP SAXENA

Questions and answers to the previous daily quiz:

1. This Ministry is responsible for the administration of the National Film Awards. **Ans: Information and Broadcasting**
 2. The only actress to be honoured for her performances in two different films at the same time. **Ans: Kangana Ranaut**
 3. Mammooty has won four National Awards so far. He shares this achievement with another actor. **Ans: Amitabh Bachchan**
 4. This person has won the maximum number of National Awards under the 'best feature film' category. **Ans: Satyajit Ray**
 5. In 2024, some prestigious categories were renamed. The award for best debut film was under the name of a former Prime Minister and the award for best feature film on national integration under the name of a famous actor. **Ans: Indira Gandhi; Nargis Dutt**
- Visual: The subject of the first Indian motion picture and the man who made the motion picture. **Ans: Raja Harishchandra; Dadasaheb Phalke**
- Early birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Mohan Lal Patel | C. Saravanan | Sunil Madhavan



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

I was scolded for forgetting my homework

The school's infrastructure was in dire straits due to lack of funds

S. Upendran

What is the meaning and origin of the expression 'dire straits'? (R. Sivakumar, Erode)

First, let us deal with the pronunciation of the two words. 'Dire' rhymes with 'higher', 'fire' and 'tyre', while 'strait' is pronounced like the word 'straight'. The phrase is pronounced 'dier - STRAIGHTS' with the stress on the second word. When you say that you are 'in dire straits', it means that you are in deep trouble; you are in such a bad situation you are unlikely to find a solution to your problem. It is a situation which causes you a lot of worry or concern.

When the monsoon failed for the second consecutive year, farmers were in dire straits.

The team was in dire straits when their best batsman broke his foot while fielding.

America's war with Iran has made people across the world familiar with the Strait of Hormuz – which Donald Trump would like to rename 'Trump Strait'. The word 'strait' is normally used to refer to a narrow body of water flowing between land masses. This narrow stretch of water connects two large bodies of water – the Strait of Hormuz, for example, connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman. The expression 'dire straits' comes from the world of shipping, and it was mostly used to highlight the difficulty or challenge posed while navigating the narrow waters of a strait. With the passage of time, the expression took on a broader meaning. Today, it is mostly used to talk about any kind of difficulty. The word 'dire' originally meant 'fearful' and 'boding ill', but today the term is mostly used to mean 'serious or extreme'.

The people affected by the recent floods are in dire need of help.

What is the difference between 'shout at' and 'scold'? (R. Rukmani, Chennai)

One normally 'scolds' people that one has a close relationship or familiar with. When you scold someone, you normally do it because you wish to change or correct their existing behaviour. When you do this, you may choose to speak in your normal voice or increase your volume.

The teacher scolded the children for not doing their homework.

'Scolde', from which we get 'scold', was used as a noun in informal contexts to refer to an abusive and quarrelsome person. With the passage of time, the legal term 'common scold' began to be applied to women who were a public nuisance – women who argued loudly with their neighbours and abused people in public. It was only in the 14th century that 'scold' began to be used as a verb to mean 'to find fault with'.

When you 'shout at' someone, you always do so by speaking loudly; there is no attempt here to correct the behaviour of the person. You are very upset about what the person has done, and are merely giving vent to your anger.

Hemant shouted at the taxi driver for his rash driving.
upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Unctuous:

unpleasantly and excessively suave in manner or speech

Synonyms: fulsome, oleaginous, smarmy

Usage: The politician's unctuous apology failed to convince the voters.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/unctuous

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈʌŋ(k)ˈtʃʊəs/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Text & Context'

Fine print:
Barely read
and rarely
understood

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

In one of the recent pieces on this page, I had emphasised that we must read and understand the insurance policy we are buying. Because once bought, the wording of the contract is binding. I got quite a few responses to that and the preceding pieces, all focusing on the effort needed to understand your policy.

One of them, from a smart neighbour, said, “Good points, Nitya. But for ordinary people there is so much fine print that it is boring. The language is confusing. If we get the non-negotiables as bullet points, it will be very easy to just see that those conditions are met and we can sign.”

She was so right, and yet wrong. They are all there. If we read them – labour over them, actually – we would probably piece together the broad picture. But understanding? That’s a different animal.

The information is all there. Lots of it, in fact. But its presence doesn’t equal comprehension.

What exactly do we mean by “understanding” a policy?

It is not recognising the words, though you will find quite a few that are centuries old.

It is not managing to finish the document, though that’s an achievement in itself. Why? The simplest policy is 12 pages long. And those are fine-print-in-9-point-font-and-double-column-format pages. I have even seen policies printed in blue font. Pretty but pointless.

It is not even being able to repeat what a clause says. I should be able to tell what it means for me, in a real situation, when I have a claim, for example.

I tried this in a formal setting. I gave a couple of bright ladies a hospitalisation policy document, asked them to read through it. One of them immediately asked, “Is this the Constitution?”

I must have looked confused so she pointed to the first paragraph of the document, “it says ‘Preamble’ she said. I peeked over to see what was on her page. It read, “This policy is a contract of insurance issued by XYZ Insurance Company Limited (hereinafter called the ‘Company’) to the proposer mentioned in the schedule (hereinafter called the ‘Insured’) to cover the person(s) named in the schedule (hereinafter called the ‘Insured Persons’)”.

Her next comment I could not but agree with. “Why do I need this?” she asked, genuinely puzzled. Why indeed.

Non-starter

If she had said she did not want to continue further, I would have understood perfectly. In fact, it happened with another person. Peering seriously for a few minutes at the blue-printed document she laid it down emphatically and said, “No, Nitya, I can’t do this.”

Forget reading it or discovering that insurance policies also have preambles, she just couldn’t physically read it. And this a self-taught veteran who handles property and stock market investments by herself.

There were other comments to come. When asked for first impressions on reading through a page or two, a gentleman remarked that it was written defensively, as if they rushing to make clear what they would not do.

Providing 40 pages of information does not necessarily mean the reader will understand it.

I will take you through the rocky path of trying to understand actual insurance policies in future installments of CoverNote.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in The experts on personal finance will answer select queries. Moneywise will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular.



Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, while PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum. ILLUSTRATION: B. SAINATH

A data-driven analysis of mutual funds vs. PMS

Across a entire 10-year period, mutual funds delivered an average return of 14.5% CAGR, outperforming the PMS average of 14.0% CAGR by 50 bps, ICRA and PMS Bazaar data show

WHITHER WEALTH

Rushabh Desai

In the Indian wealth management landscape, portfolio management services (PMS) are frequently positioned as a premium upgrade over equity mutual funds. Targeted at high-net-worth individuals (HNIs), PMS strategies theoretically promise bespoke strategy execution, unconstrained stock selection, and superior alpha generation. However, empirical market data evaluating returns over the long term reveals a more nuanced reality: higher entry tickets and concentrated strategies do not automatically translate to superior performance.

An analysis of 10-year annualised return distributions across 79 equity mutual funds (Regular Growth) and 73 equity PMS schemes spanning the Flexi Cap, Large & Mid Cap, Multi Cap, Mid Cap, and Small Cap categories provides critical data on how these two investment structures have actually performed over a decade.

According to data from ICRA and PMS Bazaar, as of August 31, 2026, equity mutual funds generated a higher 10-year average return compared with equity PMS strategies. Across the entire 10-year period, mutual funds delivered an average return of 14.5% CAGR, outperforming the PMS average of 14.0%



Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, whereas PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum

CAGR by 50 basis points. While the gap may appear modest on paper, it suggests that the higher ticket size and the higher risk taken in PMS strategies are not necessarily justified by the baseline returns. However, the average is the least interesting metric here; the real story lies in the return distribution between the two structures.

Mutual funds exhibited a tight clustering around consistency, whereas PMS strategies displayed a wide, fat-tail dispersion at both ends of the spectrum. A decent 12% of PMS strategies failed to cross the 10% CAGR mark over 10 years.

In contrast, only 1% of mutual funds fell into this underperforming bracket. An investor choosing a random equity PMS strategy faced a 1-in-8 probability of delivering returns below typical long-term risk-free rates plus inflation, whereas the regulatory diversification of mutual funds effectively insulated 99% of schemes above this threshold. An overwhelming majority of mutual funds (98% of all schemes) delivered solid wealth compounding



A decent 12% of PMS strategies failed to cross the 10% CAGR mark over 10 years. In contrast, only 1% of MFs fell into this underperforming bracket

between 10% and 20% CAGR (62% in the 10-15% bucket and 36% in the 15-20% bucket). In comparison, PMS strategies achieved a combined 84% in this range (51% in the 10-15% bucket and 33% in the 15-20% bucket). Ultimately, mutual funds demonstrated far higher consistency in hitting the median market growth corridor.

True advantage

However, PMS demonstrated its true structural advantage at the extreme top end of performance. Approximately 4% of PMS strategies generated blowout returns exceeding 20% CAGR over 10 years, compared to just 1% of mutual funds.

For investors seeking exceptional alpha generation, PMS offered a 4x higher probability of identifying top-decile outlier managers, though the absolute odds of landing there were still just 4 in 100. Understanding why these distributions diverge requires examining the regulatory frameworks and portfolio construction mechanics of both structures:

PMS portfolios typically hold concentrated bets. When top convictions pay off, PMS strategies can hit multi-bagger trajectories. Conversely, when core bets underperform, the lack of diversification leads to a severe long-term return drag.

Equity mutual funds operate under strict categorical mandates. PMS managers, on the other hand, possess near-total flexibility to move across cash, market-cap segments, and sectoral themes. While advantageous, this unconstrained tactical allocation increases the risk of human error, widening the performance dispersion.

PMS offerings frequently incorporate performance fees, management fees, and transaction charges that create higher hurdles for generating net alpha. Additionally, portfolio rebalancing in a PMS incurs direct capital gains tax events for the individual account holder, whereas mutual funds rebalance inside the pool tax-free.

None of this means PMS is a poor product; rather, it is a distinctly different structure that performs in cycles. Success requires thorough due diligence and selecting the right fund manager capable of capturing top-quartile concentrated upside over the medium to long term. In PMS strategies, poor manager selection can result in severe capital drag.

(The writer is Founder - Rupee With Rushabh Investment Services)

Managing inflation risk

THINKINVESTOR

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Both working executives and retirees are exposed to inflation risk, but retirees are affected more when price levels increase. In this article, we discuss inflation risk in relation to retirees and explore how they can manage this risk.

Hedging issue

Inflation risk is the likelihood that inflation is greater than expected. You will factor in inflation for determining your terminal wealth for a goal. If you are saving to fund your child’s college education, you will factor in education inflation to arrive at the amount you will need when your child enters college. Similarly, when you determine the amount you need at retirement, you must estimate the general inflation during your post-retirement years.

The risk you are exposed to is the likelihood that actual inflation will be greater than the expected inflation you factored into your retirement portfolio calculation.

Note that we are referring to general inflation that will affect your living expenses, not the health-care inflation.

The latter is typically more than double that of general inflation and can increase even when general inflation is in line with expectation.

If you are nearing retirement and are concerned about inflation risk, how should you manage the risk?

A hedge typically works when the investment product value rises in line with the increase in price level. Actual inflation can be greater than expected inflation because of rising commodity prices, especially crude oil.

So, you can buy investment products that take exposure to such commodities to hedge inflation risk. But products for the mass-affluent to hedge inflation risk are unavailable in India. Note that gold and equity investments may not be a good hedge against inflation.

Conclusion

Commodities futures typically offer a good hedge against inflation but have high downside risk and may be unsuitable for mass-affluent retirees. An alternative is rental property. Rental income may not be a hedge against inflation, but rentals can continually increase.

It is optimal to buy a new property just before retirement to earn market rentals. Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) are an affordable alternative for those who do not want to invest lump-sum amount from their retirement corpus into rental properties. REITs are like mutual funds that invest in commercial properties to earn lease rentals.

As per SEBI regulation, REITs are required to distribute 90% of their net distributable income (lease rentals minus operating expenses) to their investors every year.

This provides for stable cash flows that could increase with inflation.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.75	10,550-12,093	2,110-2,419	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.70 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 1%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.65-13.90	10,538-11,608	2,108-2,322	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	Up to 0.25%
Canara Bank**	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.50-9.30	10,019 - 10,452	NIL (Till 31.12.2026)
Federal Bank	7.90-9.00	10,114 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Indian Bank	7.55-9.65	10,031 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.13-11.63	10,169 - 11,029	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.55-14.05	10,031 - 11,647	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.30 - 9.35	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,000
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers/customers with 6 months of relationship with bank
**50% waiver on processing fee till September 30
***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on September 23

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Building a culture of insurance protection



Killer wave: Disasters like the Nepal floods show how natural catastrophe can cause big damage in minutes. AP

K.G. Krishnamoorthy Rao

The recent glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF) in Nepal is a stark reminder that climate change is real. It is also a reminder why insurance matters for everyone. After all, it is one of the few financial tools that can help build resilience by transferring a part of the risk and enabling faster recovery after catastrophic events.

And yet, for the past several years, India’s general insurance market has remained heavily under-penetrated, at roughly 1% of GDP as against the global average of over 4%. There is a need for not just more insurance policies but also a fundamental shift in how people view insurance.

The country’s growth story is hard to ignore. The economy reached sixth globally with \$3.92 trillion GDP in 2025-26. We are building across sectors, from information technology, healthcare, manufacturing, and financial services to infrastructure, e-commerce, and renewable energy. Driven by rising incomes, urbanisation and improved access to education and technology, the middle class too is growing.

The assets and wealth we create as we grow individually, and as a nation, need to be protected, especially as risks continue to rise. And yet, insurance remains misunderstood or unknown. When I joined the insurance industry about 38 years ago, I had hardly heard about any insurance product other than life insurance, and that too since a relative worked in LIC.

Awareness on insurance is still very low among the public, though after the COVID-19 pandemic there has been some increase in awareness about health insurance. However, insurance protection for homes, assets, and other risks is largely overlooked. Even when they do recognise the risks, most people tend to insure what is mandatory rather than what is financially important. Motor insurance is a case in point. It is often purchased because the law requires it, rather than because vehicle owners understand the financial implications of an accident.

Similarly, many homeowners think “nothing will happen to my home”, and do not think of property insurance. This is why the next phase of insurance growth will require the industry to sell not just policies but an understanding of risk.

There have been some awareness initiatives from the insurance regulator. However, disasters such as the most recent one in Nepal, the Assam floods this year, or the 2024 Wayanad landslide have shown us that NatCat (natural catastrophe) events can cause enormous damage to property and lives within minutes.

And in a world with intensifying climate risks, safeguarding your assets is the only logical thing to do. There is a lot to learn from disaster management. Governments may step in after a disaster to rebuild homes and restore livelihoods. But beyond that, the responsibility for maintaining and protecting those assets returns to the individual. Insurance can help households absorb future shocks without having to start over.

(The writer is the MD and CEO of Generali Central Insurance)

Backlash against mega data centres gains momentum, AI’s hidden cost

Communities living near data centres push back against the water and power guzzling, the noise, heat and uncertain local benefits; backlash puts countries such as India in a quandary as they compete aggressively for the next wave of investment from hyperscaler companies

NEWS ANALYSIS

Vallari Sanzgiri

Meena (name changed), a resident of Kalpataru in Balkum, Thane, keeps buckets filled at home. Water cuts can last for days, while power outages are a regular summer feature. So when Amazon acquired the plot next to her housing society, the residents welcomed the news. Many expected the tech giant’s office nearby to bring higher rentals and improved infrastructure to an area that struggled with water shortages.

Instead, they learnt that the site would house a data centre – a large digital storehouse packed with racks and servers – which typically requires millions of litres of water a day for cooling.

“Last week, we had no water for five days... how will they supply the data centre,” Meena asks *businessline*.

Her question finds an echo far beyond Thane – from Melbourne to Ireland and Italy – as the communities living near data centres push back against the water and power guzzling, the noise, heat and uncertain local benefits. In Melbourne, Jacqui Glover, president of the New Citizens of Tottenham group, said, “Cloud is not invisible. It is made of concrete, steel and relentless noise. Living across the street from it changes your relationship with your own home.”

The backlash puts countries such as India in a quandary as they compete aggressively for the next wave of investment from hyperscaler companies – Amazon Web Services (AWS), Microsoft Azure, Google Cloud et al. How to build infrastructure for the AI economy without passing the environmental and social costs to host communities?

A typical 100 MW hyperscaler data centre can consume nearly 2 million litres of water per day for on-site cooling, according to the Council on Energy, Environment and Water or CEEW. This is equivalent to supplying about 15,000 urban residents, as per government estimates.

For its next 1 GW AI data centre in India, Google has picked Visakhapatnam, in Andhra Pradesh, a region already grappling with



Parched patch: For its next 1 GW AI data centre in India, Google has picked Vizag, a region already grappling with “overexploited” groundwater, according to a Central Ground Water Board report. V. RAJU

“overexploited” groundwater, according to the Central Ground Water Board’s 2025 report.

While a conventional data centre meant for general business applications required 5-15 kW power per hour, an AI data centre with high-performance graphics processing units (GPUs) needs 40-60kWh, or even 100-plus kWh for cutting-edge AI training facilities – enough to power 1,000 fridges for an hour. Data centres accounted for around 1.5% of global electricity consumption in 2024, with demand projected to double to 945 TWh by 2030, as per a CEEW report.

“Average rack power density is expected to rise from 36 kW per rack in 2023 to 50 kW per rack by 2027, and the economics of AI infrastructure are scaling up at the same pace. Most enterprise data centres were not built for any of this,” Rahul Dhar, President-Global Datacenter Operations, CtrlS Datacenters, wrote in a company blogpost.

Land use for AI data centres is another area of concern, as it entails the clearing and conversion of large tracts, apart from the environmental contamination risks associated with water treatment chemicals, fuel storage and the presence of hazardous materials like lead and mercury in electronic equipment, Sushant Sarin, Managing Director and Head of Commercial Risk Solutions-India, Aon says.

Across the protests globally is the call for regulatory transparency. The WakeUp Thanekar group spearheading the protest against the Amazon data centre in Thane has written to local authorities for details such as the develop-



How are they deciding where to situate the data centres? We need to look at the impacts before becoming a hub

ARPITHA KODIVERI, Comparative environmental law scholar and assistant professor of political science, Vassar College

ment plan, zoning classification, control regulations and permissions.

In Visakhapatnam, the project documents are readily available but there is no clarity on details like the available water source.

While local data centre players confirm the need for environmental clearance due to generator usage, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change said in response to a parliamentary question on data centres in August that such projects do not require environmental clearance “per se”.

“Then how are they deciding where to situate the data centres? We need to look at the impacts before becoming a hub,” Arpitha Kodiveri, comparative environmental law scholar and assistant professor of political science at Vassar College in New York, says.

Lombardy, in Italy, has enforced regional environmental laws to regulate the siting of data centres, including energy thresholds. For example, structures with 5 MW or less capacity are deemed ‘edge’ data centres permissible within urban areas, whereas a 10 MW centre would require a territorial agreement, including compensatory measures. Ireland has ruled that data centre companies should generate their own power, 80% of it on-site renewable.

Most countries current-

ly regulate data centres by combining fragmented frameworks across cybersecurity, infrastructure development, and land acquisition.

India, in 2020, released a Draft National Data Centre Policy outlining single-clearance windows, economic zones, renewable energy focus and domestic manufacturing. But since it has not been notified, protests continue to simmer.

Compliance also aids client conversations. Foreign funding for data centres in India has cooled from \$600-900 million a month in the first half of 2026 to around \$100 million in the following months, as per Tracxn.

Kranthi Bathini, Director of Equity Strategy at WealthMills Securities, attributed this to fears over project delays due to the protests. Interest picked up in September when Swedish private equity firm EQT announced plans to invest around \$30 billion.

At the State level, Karnataka recently approved a Sustainable Data Centre Policy to achieve 1 GW capacity by 2031. It proposes a ₹1,300.45 crore revised budget to create 10-12% of India’s AI-ready data centre capacity.

Official response

Responding to the concerns flagged by residents, hyperscalers told *businessline* they are working on sustainable measures. AWS says its Thane data centre will use a closed-loop chemical coolant instead of water. For power, it will connect to the high-voltage transmission grid through its dedicated industrial substation.

On the opposite coast, in Visakhapatnam, Google

talks of pairing the data centre with a multi-variable response spread over three to five years, including new subsea cable landings, power utility infrastructure, clean energy generation, and a centralised logistics centre.

Recruitment is on to ensure the AI Hub is fully staffed for eventual day-one operations, says Alexander Smith, Principal, Global Infrastructure and Energy, Asia Pacific, Google. A “long-term local talent pipeline and local supplier ecosystem” would be established to support multi-decade operations, he adds.

He says independent environment audits are being used to design facilities, including advanced air-cooled systems and sound-dampening fans “to ensure we are a quiet, unobtrusive neighbour”.

As for power consumption, he points to the company’s standard use of 83% less overhead energy than the industry average. It is also investing in clean energy generation in Andhra Pradesh and across India.

Aon’s Sarin points to real-time advanced energy management systems, and digital twins and predictive maintenance tools to improve operational reliability.

“The challenge is less about technological feasibility and more about scaling them economically while balancing performance, sustainability and resilience objectives,” he says.

businessline attempted but received no response from Vizag district officers. Meanwhile, Education, IT and Electronics Minister Nara Lokesh had informed the Legislative Assembly on August 19 that Godavari river water would be diverted through the Polavaram project for the data centre. He added that the targeted 6.5 GW ecosystem for Vizag will require 3 tmc of water annually (1 tmc is around 28.3 billion litres). The Human Rights Forum points to the discrepancy with the 3.5 tmc cited on August 12 by Chief Minister Chandrababu Naidu.

“It concerns an enormous quantity of water in an already water-stressed Visakhapatnam,” it said in a public statement..

On the business side, the call for regulation is more nuanced. One of the reasons India is keen to enter the data centre market

is the potential tax revenue. The government anticipates over \$200 billion tax revenue, contributing to achieving a \$30-trillion economy by 2047, as per Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal.

Between 2019 and 2025, committed investments reached nearly \$95 billion, as per CEEW. A light-touch approach would help maintain this enthusiasm, an industry source argues.

The global call for data sovereignty has also pushed many hyperscalers to invest in long-term contracts to set up local data centres in major markets. Local players worry that the “misguided” and “harmful” dissent will cost India such big-ticket projects. ESDS Software Solutions had even flagged local protests as a risk in its draft red herring prospectus.

Union Minister Jitendra Singh had projected nearly one lakh engineering jobs at an industry meet on ‘Future-proofing India’s data centres’. Protesters in Vizag counter this with the Google data centre’s environment impact assessment report, which mentions just 1,200 jobs, in a marked variance from the reported figure of 1.8 lakh jobs. They question the rationale for offering government subsidies to hyperscaler data centres that offer no domestic benefit.

As of January this year, India hosts around 271 data centres, spread across 23 million sq m, in six metro cities. From 1.5 GW by mid-2025, installed data centre capacity is projected to reach 4.5-6.5 GW by 2030, but still nowhere near the 500 GW capacity in the U.S. and China.

While the country targets 500 GW green energy capacity by 2030, the reliance on State policies remains a crutch.

It worsens a widening gap between India’s investment-led data centre expansion and global shifts towards performance-based sustainability regulation, as per CEEW.

“If the public cost is real, the public dividend must also be real. If data centres consume local power and water without creating broad digital capability, India will have built impressive infrastructure but a poor national bargain,” warns Sanchit Vir Gogia, Chief Analyst and Founder of Greyhound Research.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Behind the scenes of unfolding inglorious boardroom battles

Kamal Karanth

When I was younger, most workplace fights ended with a movie or a drink, and we eventually laughed about it. As I got older, every difference of opinion, every increment, every promotion got my colleagues to quit on me. Though we shook hands and parted, some of us have never met since.

I tend to think I will never have a fallout with my co-founder. However, age is a funny thing; my sense is that what brought a younger neighbour, friend, colleague or co-founder together may not necessarily be enough in the face of a major boardroom conflict tomorrow. After all, leaders have to make major decisions, amid two differing

sides of emotion. One can rationalise saying conflict is like a gym for any leader – you have to be at it to get fitter. Do strong differences of opinion get compounded with age, when power egos rise? As I hear about boardroom conflicts, notably the Tata Sons one, I wonder if an ageing board compounds arguments into fights.

Ageing boards

Most boards are filled with aged men, and not everyone is a wizard like Warren Buffett to deserve to preside till 96. We tend to believe experience serves boards well, and hence global brands have reasonably aged members. It may sound weird to suggest that aged boards create more conflicts, given that



Ego war: It makes one wonder if an ageing board compounds arguments into fights. PTI

these listed companies are the most scrutinised and also financially successful.

Why do boards think they need aged members by their side? A 2023 study on CEO age and firm per-

formance by Florida Atlantic University suggests that older CEOs exhibit significantly lower managerial ability in high-technology firms. While ageing is often associated with greater ex-

perience and ability, the research warns it can also lead to significant decrease in cognitive function, energy, ambition and, consequently, managerial ability.

Should we bet on youth

to lead enterprises? The founder-led executive suite in top Indian unicorns averages 34-38 years, backed by an external supervisory board in the 55-64 age bracket, balancing execution agility with governance. However, the young guns aren’t making a case for themselves. The startup world’s mortality rate is high, and the prominent reason seems to be co-founder conflict. In his book *The Founder’s Dilemma*, Harvard Business School professor Noam Wasserman claims that 65 per cent of high-potential startups fail due to conflict among co-founders. CB Insights, a market intelligence platform, lists disharmony in teams as among the top 10 reasons for startup failures. The ar-

gument that younger leaders will have fewer fights doesn’t hold either!

Selectivity theory

Laura Carstensen, a Stanford psychologist, developed a lifespan theory of motivation – called Socioemotional Selectivity Theory (SST) – which posits that people change goals and priorities based on how much time they have left in life. When people perceive future time horizons as shorter, they prioritise emotionally meaningful goals by savouring the present, investing in sure things, and deepening close relationships rather than seeking new connections. This shift in goals impacts values, preferences, and decision-making. According to SST, older adults

prefer to interact with emotionally close partners rather than peripheral social partners, even dropping the latter to increase the emotional density of their social networks. I wonder whether SST can give a new dimension to the ongoing tussle at the Tata board. Some want to hold on to what is sure, and some are looking at a new dawn. Appointing a diverse board has been in vogue for a while now. Fortune 100 and S&P 500 companies now have about 34% female representation. However, 40% of the last 100 American unicorns still have 100% all-male board composition.

(Kamal Karanth is co-founder of Xpheno, a specialist staffing firm)

BEIJING

China sends two giant pandas to U.S. following Trump-Xi summit



Two giant pandas sent by China arrived in the United States on Sunday, Beijing's state media said, after the Washington summit between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping. China loans the mammals as part of a "panda diplomacy" programme to foster foreign ties. The pandas will be hosted by the Atlanta zoo for 10 years. AFP

JOHANNESBURG

Police search for perpetrators after 27 die in shootings in South Africa



South African police were on Sunday searching for the perpetrators of two separate shootings that killed 27 people in Johannesburg and Cape Town, in the latest criminal violence to hit the country. President Cyril Ramaphosa said security forces "are going to continue pulling out all stops" to put an end to criminality. REUTERS

KATHMANDU

10 people missing after avalanche hits camp at Nepal's Himlung peak



At least 10 local climbers and guides are missing after an avalanche hit the base camp of the 7,126-metre tall Himlung peak in Nepal on Sunday, an expedition organiser said. The Himalayan country is already reeling from a devastating, tsunami-like flood on August 26 that killed more than 1,400 people and left over 6,000 missing. AFP

GENEVA

Swiss voters reject plan to toughen neutrality rules in key referendum



Swiss voters on Sunday rejected a plan to tighten their country's neutrality, dismissing an initiative championed by the hard-right. The proposal was rejected by 70.1% of voters, according to the final results. The proposal emerged following Switzerland's decision to join EU sanctions against Russia over its war in Ukraine. AFP

Iran stands firm on plan to reopen Hormuz after Trump rejects move

Tehran insists on diplomacy, but says it has never backed down from its rights; the proposal seeks cessation of all hostilities in the region, lifting of sanctions and release of frozen assets; U.S. envoy to the UN calls the deal cynical for asking too much

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON, TEHRAN

Iran stood firm on Sunday on its conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz, despite U.S. President Donald Trump's rejection of the proposal, leaving the war in West Asia locked in a stalemate.

Iran's plan called for a cessation of all hostilities in the region, including in Lebanon, according to Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, and a return to the conditions in the ceasefire deal that fell apart a few months ago.

That agreement had called for the release of frozen Iranian assets, the lift-



Ocean view: A boy stands with his bicycle on a beach overlooking vessels anchored in the Strait of Hormuz off Bandar Abbas, Iran. AP

ing of sanctions on Iranian oil and an end to the U.S. naval blockade.

"Our conditions are clear, and any move toward reopening Hormuz is contingent upon these conditions being fulfilled.

We will not back down from them," Mr. Araghchi said on Sunday, according to state media. "We have never closed the door to diplomacy, but we have also never backed down from our rights."

But Mr. Trump said on Saturday that he rejected the truce deal. "They want to make a deal where they open the Strait immediately because they're losing so badly," he told reporters.

His Ambassador to the UN, Mike Waltz, accused Tehran of demanding too much in exchange for a return to the negotiating table. "This was, I think, a pretty cynical attempt to put something on the table that they knew was unacceptable. To ask for the release of the blockade, the sanctions, international sanctions and access to billions in assets, just to talk," he said.

Meanwhile, Iran's Revolutionary Guards said that

they seized an American submarine drone on Sunday in the Strait of Hormuz. It said the underwater vehicle was being used "for espionage purposes".

Economic isolation

Hailing new restrictions targeting Iran's airlines and banks, U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Saturday that Washington's efforts to pressure countries to economically isolate Iran was delivering results.

"At my direction, teams were dispatched across the globe to engage with countries and demand action against Tehran," he said on X. "These efforts are delivering results".

Five held near U.K. airbase used by U.S. during Iran war

Agence France-Presse
FAIRFORD

British counter-terrorism forces were probing "a major incident" near a base used by the U.S. Air Force in its war against Iran after arresting five men on suspicion of "preparing a terrorist act", the police said on Sunday.

Armed officers detained the group in the early hours after a call to emergency services about three "suspicious vehicles which appeared to be travelling towards the air base", London's Metropolitan Police said in a statement.

'Big damage'

U.S. President Donald Trump said that the suspects were aiming to do significant damage to the base.

"We had them under investigation... they were

The suspects were arrested near the Fairford airbase; U.K. counter-terrorism police lead probe

looking to do big damage to our fort, and working with the British worked out great," Mr. Trump said. "We had them under view for a long time, and we got them."

The suspects were initially held near the Royal Air Force Fairford air base in Gloucestershire on suspicion of carrying explosives. Some 85 households in the nearby village of Whelford were advised to evacuate and army bomb disposal experts were called in.

Prime Minister Andy Burnham was being kept updated on the incident, a British government spo-

kesperson said. "We are grateful to the emergency services, who have acted quickly to detain several suspects and put measures in place to keep the community safe," the spokesperson said.

In March, then Prime Minister Keir Starmer granted permission for "defensive" U.S. action against Iranian missile sites from two U.K. bases including Fairford.

Defence Minister Wes Streeting thanked "emergency and specialist teams" deployed to the scene. "We can be reassured that this is being dealt with," he said on X.

Fairford is the U.K. base of the 501st Combat Support Wing, a U.S. air force administrative support wing, which said in a statement that no U.S. air force personnel had been involved in the incident.

Deep waters



People wade through a flooded area during heavy rain in Bangkok, Thailand, on Sunday. More than 13 inches of rain fell in some areas of the capital city between Thursday and Sunday, the weather agency said. Nearly 4,900 people have been evacuated to shelters. REUTERS

Vucic resigns as Serbian President, to run for PM

Agence France-Presse
BELGRADE

Serbia's President Aleksandar Vucic resigned on Sunday to run for Prime Minister in October snap poll after nearly two years of student-led protests.

"I am resigning as President," Mr. Vucic said. "Tomorrow morning I will hand over my duties to the Parliament Speaker."

The snap election was a key demand of a student-led movement sparked by the November 2024 collapse of a canopy at Novi Sad railway station that killed 16 people and was blamed on corruption.

Under the law, Speaker Ana Brnabic becomes acting President for up to three months, during which a presidential election must be called.

Israeli Minister calls for war in West Bank, seizure of Gaza areas

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich called on Sunday for the annexation of parts of south Lebanon and the Gaza Strip and for Israeli forces to "go to war" against Palestinians in the occupied West Bank.

"I would like us to annex at least as far as the yellow line in Gaza and as far as the Litani River in Lebanon... because if a war ends along the same lines where it began, what will deter the enemy from go-

ing to war again," Mr. Smotrich said.

"I think we need to go to war in Judea and Samaria, to dismantle the Palestinian Authority that supports terror," he added, using the biblical term for the West Bank. The Palestinian Authority condemned Mr. Smotrich's call for war in the West Bank.

Meanwhile, Gaza's Health Ministry said on Saturday the Palestinian death toll rose to 74,016 people during the nearly three-year Israel-Hamas war.

Eight killed in Ukraine as Russia says it hit military infra, data centres, vessels

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Russian strikes killed eight people across Ukraine a day after Moscow vowed to achieve its war aims "no matter the circumstances", Ukrainian authorities said on Sunday.

Interior Minister Ivan Vyhivskiy said Russian strikes hit Sumy, killing three people including a 16-year-old girl.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said three people were killed in nighttime strikes in Zaporizhzhia and a drone strike had killed one man in Kyiv.



Mangled remains: A firefighter works at the site of a warehouse hit by a Russian drone strike in Kyiv, Ukraine on Sunday. REUTERS

"The enemy continues to relentlessly attack the Kyiv region with strike drones," the city's administration said.

Authorities in the Odesa

region said a "massive strike" on the south of the Black Sea region had killed one more person.

The Russian Defence Ministry said on Sunday its

forces struck two drone storages in Mykolaiv, the headquarters of a naval base and military stores in Kiliya port. A cargo ship carrying military goods to the port of Odesa was also struck, it said.

A Kyivstar data centre in Kyiv and another belonging to the Omega Telecom company was also bombed, it said.

The attacks came a day after Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov told the UN that Moscow intends to continue its military campaign "to the end". (With inputs from Reuters)

28 fighters 'sent from Pakistan' killed and 32 captured: Taliban

Associated Press
KABUL

Afghanistan's Taliban government said on Sunday that its forces killed 28 fighters and captured 32 others, including alleged members of the Islamic State group said to have crossed from Pakistan.

Taliban-run Defence Ministry said in a post on X that the fighters were killed or captured on Saturday in Kamdesh district in Nuristan. It alleged that several IS-affiliated groups had been sent from Pakistan

"with the aim of carrying out acts of subversion and creating insecurity."

Pakistan's Ministry of Information rejected the allegations as "frivolous, baseless and devoid of any truth."

Meanwhile, Pakistan's military said on Sunday that its forces had killed more than 71 militants in operations in Balochistan over the last 96 hours.

Tensions between the two countries have increased in recent days over cross-border fighting and Pakistani airstrikes.



People block the Garvaghy road, a Catholic enclave in the largely Protestant town of Portadown, on Sunday. REUTERS

Northern Ireland tense after nod to contentious march

Associated Press
LONDON

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham called for calm in Northern Ireland on Sunday after a contentious parade was given the go-ahead by the High Court in Belfast in a late-night sitting.

Thousands of protesters, many wearing balaclavas, gathered to block the marchers from the Orange Order, a group hugely supportive of Northern Ireland being part of the U.K., from proceeding down a street in the town of Portadown, where many favour unification with the Republic of Ireland.

It's the first time in nearly 30 years that the Orange Order parade has been allowed to go down the Garvaghy Road, which had been a notorious flashpoint between the communities in the years before the Good Friday Agreement of 1998 largely ended the bloodshed in Northern Ireland. During the so-called Troubles, some 3,600 people were killed while some 50,000 were wounded.

Ending the Troubles meant balancing competing identities in Northern Ireland, which remained in the United Kingdom when the rest of Ireland won independence a century ago. Irish nationalists in the north – most of them Catholic – seek union with the Republic of Ireland, while largely Protestant unionists want to stay part of the U.K.

Mr. Burnham appealed for “calm on all sides” over the parade, saying there have been “big gains made in Northern Ireland, and we don’t want to see things go backwards.”

Jon Boucher, the head of the Police Service of Northern Ireland, called for “those with influence to encourage people to comply with the law,” referring to a protest blocking the Garvaghy Road.

Industry giants sound the alarm on AI safety, seek to shape how it’s controlled

By calling for slowdown and independent evaluators, companies such as Anthropic and OpenAI try to position themselves as safe bets for investors against smaller competitors; it may also be to score political goals ahead of the upcoming U.S. midterm elections when the political winds could shift

Associated Press
SAN FRANCISCO

As tech titans warned an AI-weary world that their own advanced systems could endanger humanity, the question emerged: What do they have to gain?

The answer may lie in the companies’ efforts to score political goals ahead of the U.S. midterm elections and the money top artificial intelligence labs and their investors stand to make in much-anticipated listings on a jittery stock market.

The CEOs of Anthropic and OpenAI recently declared America’s cutting-edge models are so powerful, they’re dangerous, and need to be regulated and independently tested before being released. In a rare instance of unity, they have sketched alarming scenarios in essays, social media posts and speeches to the United Nations.

Along the way, they are shaping the conversation around how their technology should be controlled. With their rhetoric, the companies appear to be seeking public favour and to set the terms for their own safety protocols in the unregulated market, experts, analysts and former government evaluators told *The Associated Press*.

Those aims may not exactly align with what Anthropic engineer Jacob Coxon sought when he

quit via a post on X this month, calling for a pause on tech development to keep “superhuman” systems from eluding their makers’ control. But the companies saw his post as an opportunity to highlight their own safety efforts and position themselves as cautious market leaders, just when they need fresh capital before going public on Wall Street.

President Donald Trump has shunned the need for new AI regulations, dismissing talk of risks to humanity as a “HOAX” designed to help China.

An Anthropic spokesperson said that the company has been calling for regulation for several years. An OpenAI spokesperson, Liz Bourgeois, noted the company recently paused training of its most advanced models. “People want to know AI is being developed safely, and that starts with what companies like ours do ourselves,” Ms. Bourgeois said.

Diversion tactic

Turning the conversation toward unproven threats – and away from polarising issues such as data centres’ environmental impacts, uncontrolled hacking incidents, mass AI-powered surveillance and the AI systems’ use in warfare – puts Silicon Valley in a more comfortable position, said Sarah Shoker, who previously led OpenAI’s geo-



The CEOs of Anthropic and OpenAI recently declared America’s cutting-edge models are so powerful, they are dangerous, and need to be regulated and independently tested before being released. REUTERS

politics team.

“Once again we’re talking about existential risk, while deprioritizing a number of other safety-critical risks that exist today. If you look at the use of AI in military tech, you can see that these systems are already used to kill people,” said Ms. Shoker, a senior non-resident fellow at University of California, Berkeley Risk & Security Lab.

In recent months, leading labs’ AI agents have hacked into external websites after being allowed to escape company training sandboxes, interacted with U.S. government websites in unexpected ways, and appeared to achieve a mathematical breakthrough only to face accusations of stealing mathematicians’ work.

OpenAI representatives recently said they have talked with AI companies including Anthropic and Google about pausing development. They also argue they need independent auditors to check the labs’ progress, if the government won’t regulate.

Mr. Trump has shown little interest in regulating AI, which has been a major driver of recent U.S. economic growth. The Republican President himself has struck deals with Silicon Valley firms that more closely tie the economy to their successes.

The reality is the Trump administration already evaluates some of the tech giants’ models through a little-known federal agency, the U.S. Center for AI Standards and Innovation

(CAISI). Democratic President Joe Biden created the agency in 2023, when it was heralded as a clearinghouse for labs to voluntarily submit advanced AI models for testing.

The agency still exists, but the field has since expanded to include an array of independent evaluation firms, such as Berkeley, California-based non-profit METR, which Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei suggested in a recent essay could help vet his company’s safety practices.

But there are no universal standards for how to test the safety and security of AI systems, said Andrew Strait, who recently left the United Kingdom’s AI Security Institute, which worked with CAISI.

Notably, the companies

are not calling for more oversight from the government agency equipped to handle such requests, said Conrad Stosz, who previously led CAISI. Instead, they vow to create their own auditing parameters and choose particular evaluators to grade them.

Bid to lure investors

Mr. Stosz now works at one such evaluation lab that has worked with Anthropic, OpenAI and Google to test their systems, and also chairs the AI Evaluator Forum, which is drafting best practices for the field. He said even the forum has questions about what Mr. Amodei and OpenAI CEO Sam Altman want.

For Harrison Rolfes, a Pitchbook senior research analyst, AI companies’ calls for caution seem meant to curry favour with investors ahead of public offerings and the midterms, when the political winds could shift. Democratic governors already are rushing to show they’re taking the warnings seriously.

Meanwhile, the AI giants can block smaller competitors’ growth by positioning themselves as the safest bet for investors, as well as for AI chipmakers and tech companies such as Nvidia and Google, which in turn can benefit from deals that provide the giant AI companies compute power, Mr. Rolfes said.

Midterms: Republicans pour money into dozens of ‘safe’ U.S. House races

Reuters
NEW YORK

Republicans are pouring money into more than three dozen U.S. House races previously considered “safe” after internal polling showed they could be vulnerable in the November 3 election, according to three Republican operatives familiar with the party’s thinking.

The shift is already starting to show in advertising reservations and campaign finance filings. Since September 1, major Republican groups and mega donors have begun spending in at least 39 congressional races where they have not previously deployed money this cycle, a Reuters re-



A representative illustration

view of spending by some of the largest Republican political groups shows.

Many of the candidates receiving new support sit in Republican strongholds and are still running ahead in public polls, these people said, indicating rising worry among party leaders

over whether voters will use the November 3 election to air dissatisfaction over President Donald Trump’s policies.

Republicans currently hold a narrow 218-214 majority in the House. Democrats would need to net at least four seats in the midterms to take control of the chamber next year.

Republican Representative Bryan Steil’s Wisconsin district voted for Mr. Trump by about 4.5 percentage points in 2024. Still, conservative super PACs dumped \$1.5 million on his race this month, their first investment of this election cycle.

In North Carolina’s 3rd Congressional District east of Raleigh, Representative

Gregory Murphy received \$131,107 from a conservative PAC a week ago – the first outside spending on his behalf in the midterms. Mr. Trump won the district by 14 percentage points.

One Republican House campaign aide said the environment for candidates in Iowa, Kansas and other Midwest states was “dire” as diesel prices soar.

More than \$1.56 billion, overall, has been spent by independent committees on federal elections so far.

Republicans have reserved at least \$888 million in advertising over the coming weeks, compared to at least \$666million for Democrats, according to AdImpact, which tracks political advertising.

Housing crisis



Taking to the streets: Demonstrators set up camp at Puerta del Sol to protest Spain’s housing crisis after the eviction of an 87-year-old woman from her apartment in Madrid on Sunday. REUTERS

Thousands of church sex abuse victims in France get millions in reparations

Associated Press
PARIS

As Pope Leo XIV prepares to meet on Sunday with survivors of sexual abuse by clergy in France, an independent body created to address decades of church abuse is wrapping up its work and taking stock.

France’s Independent National Authority for Recognition and Reparation, or INIRR announced this week that about 2,000 people who reported being sexually abused by priests or other church representatives have sought reparations.

France’s Catholic bishops’ conference agreed to provide compensation after a 2021 report estimated some 3,30,000 children were sexually abused over 70 years by priests or other

church-related figures. The report described a “systemic” cover-up by church officials and urged the French Catholic Church to respect the rule of law.

Over 1,184 decisions granting financial or other reparations from the church have formally been made by the INIRR.

Hundreds of other cases are still awaiting a decision. Some 183 people reached out to the independent body this year.

The INIRR closed to new submissions on August 31, after completing its scheduled mandate, but is still accompanying victims until the end of next year.

It is to be replaced by another body, meant to be permanent and focusing on restorative justice, long-term guidance, and support for victims of sexual

violence within the church. After completing the process, survivors receive a “letter of recognition” that formally acknowledges the sexual abuse and details the financial compensation.

‘Shock wave’

“The letter was a shock wave for me,” said Cécile Reneaume, 34, who received reparations from INIRR after she was abused as a young child by the leader of a Catholic community, who has since died.

“I was expecting a very small amount of financial compensation – that’s how I had imagined it. But when I read the letter, it said: ‘The church acknowledges these specific failings,’” she described.

“It meant that the little



Pope Leo arrives to meet with staff and sick pilgrims at Accueil Notre-Dame, in Lourdes, France, on Sunday. REUTERS

girl who once had been unable to speak was finally believed. It gave weight and credibility to what happened to me as a child,” Ms. Reneaume said.

The Associated Press generally does not identify victims of sexual assault or abuse unless they come forward publicly or give their consent to be identified.

Survivors who went through the process were awarded an average of 36,892 euros each.

Once the INIRR approves the financial compensation, the case is sent to a special fund financed by the church for payment.

“My first reaction was violent,” said Eric, 55, who didn’t want his last name to be public, when he was

informed of the amount. “I felt anger, disbelief. Am I worth this?”

Mr. Eric was raped by a priest when he was between ages 8 and 14.

“It took me time to understand that it wasn’t me who was being assessed, nor was it about putting a price on what I had suffered, because you can’t put a price on a childhood,” he said.

The compensation is intended to financially support the healing process.

People reaching out to INIRR last year were aged 56 on average, about two-thirds were men and one-third were women.

Among them, Philippe Gomes was 49 in 2023 when a session of therapeutic hypnosis helped him remember he had been a victim of sexual

abuse by two priests from age 7 to 12. Survivors may experience complete or partial loss of memory due to the traumatic events.

“I reached out to the INIRR and that was a real shock, because the first thing I was told was: ‘I believe you,’” Mr. Gomes said. He said the therapy he is undergoing has helped him say he was raped without crying.

“I’m not ashamed, I’m not the one who should be ashamed,” he said.

Pope’s meeting

Reparations also may include non-financial support. Requests have included help for victims to write down their stories, organising meetings with local church representatives, or installing a plaque in memory of victims.

The pope will meet privately with seven survivors on Sunday, at the Catholic pilgrimage site in Lourdes.

A group of victims asked the Pope to acknowledge the Catholic Church’s responsibility in the widespread abuse. In an open letter published on Friday by French newspaper *Liberation*, they called themselves survivors of sexual violence “from members of your community,” and expressed fears that the Pope’s visit “will change nothing.”

“Because once again you will address, as in Lourdes, victims who have been carefully selected in ‘complete confidentiality’ and, faced with crimes committed within your ranks, you limit yourself to asking us for forgiveness,” they wrote.

A IN-Y



Firm favourites: The Men in Blue are widely tipped to retain their gold from Hangzhou. x@BCCI

Skipper Shreyas wary of challenging surface as India meets Afghanistan

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The rains in Nagoya continued for the second day and threaten to affect India's quarterfinal against Afghanistan on Monday as the men's cricket team got a feel of the ground conditions with its only training session on Sunday.

The Korogi Sports Park that also hosted the women's competition is a modified baseball field and the hybrid pitch and outfield got a positive feedback from Harmanpreet Kaur & Co. The men, coming after a one-off, five-over match against Japan in Sano, have had little time to acclimatise to Nagoya while Afghanistan has already played two matches.

The continued rain also marred the team's attempts to have a full intensity training. Captain Shreyas Iyer, however, refused to dwell on the conditions or the facilities. "Yes, it's raining but we cannot give that as a reason because we are a bunch of professionals. Such hurdles will keep coming and mentally we have to be prepared, irrespective of whatever the situation is going to be. We got a decent warm-up and a little knocking. Tomorrow, we will try to adapt as soon as possible to the wickets and see how the

weather is. The important thing is to come and play the match," Shreyas said on the eve of the match.

Afghanistan lost a three-match T20I series 0-3 in New Delhi recently but the team here is very different and inexperienced. In fact, with an almost full-strength team, India is firm favourite to retain its gold medal but Shreyas insisted on being cautious. "Not only Afghanistan, Japan gave us a very good competition. The wicket here cannot be set in a particular standard. But it is very important to adapt. It will be challenging for every team," he said.

"Today when we woke up, we thought we would be getting a little bit of practice. We knew we would be playing on turf but as soon as we arrived, the rain started again. We were able to maximise a bit in terms of our warm-up and the bowlers did some strides in the background in the outfield and sent down a couple of overs," he pointed out.

With the Games entering the business end of competition, Shreyas also hoped to catch action from other sports. "Like today, we know that an 18-year-old prodigy (Anahat Singh) is playing a squash game, so we wanted to see that. But due to practice, we couldn't go. Our support is for every individual who is representing the country," he added.

ASIAD ROUND-UP



Ankush and Parveen after their quarterfinal wins. x@MEDIA_SAI

Three Indian boxers assured of medals

NISHIO: Indian boxers Parveen Hooda, Ankush Panghal and Narender Berwal assured the country of three medals with dominant quarterfinal wins at the Asian Games here on Sunday, while Sachin Siwach's campaign ended in the last eight stage. Parveen defeated World championships silver medallist Navbakhor Khamidova of Uzbekistan 5-0 to move into the women's 65kg semifinals. **The results (quarterfinals): Women: 65kg:** Parveen Hooda bt Navbakhor Khamidova (Uzb) 5-0. **Men: +90kg:** Narender Berwal bt Adthapong Saengtpe (Tha) RSC; **80kg:** Ankush Panghal bt Nekruz Salimov (Tjk) 5-0. **60kg:** Shunsuke Kitamoto (Jpn) bt Sachin Siwach 5-0.

Sindhu, Unnati bow out as India draws a blank
NAGOYA: P.V. Sindhu and Unnati Hooda went down in the women's singles quarterfinals on Sunday as Indian shuttlers failed to win a medal in the individual competition of

the Asian Games. Sindhu, forced to play her third match in less than 24 hours, lost to Chen Yu Fei of China 21-11, 18-21, 10-21. "I should have finished it off in the second game itself, but I could not. Overall, it was not an easy match. There were really long rallies," Sindhu said. "It is a bit hurtful, but I need to recover from this. It would have been good if I had gone to the semifinals. It is unfortunate but never mind... these things keep happening. It is important to get back stronger," the 31-year-old added. Unnati went down 16-21, 21-14, 17-21 to three-time World champion Akane Yamaguchi of Japan. Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand suffered an 8-21, 9-21 defeat to the Malaysian World No. 5 pairing of Pearly Tan and Thinaah Muralitharan in the doubles quarterfinals. In mixed doubles Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto lost 14-21, 21-18, 18-21 to China's World No. 1 Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dongping in the last-eight.

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

The men won the silver, and the women the bronze. India, the defending champion in both the open and women's sections, could not repeat the stunning twin success of 2024, but at least finished with medals at the Chess Olympiad in Samarkand.

In the open section, host Uzbekistan emerged the champion, while China came up with a dominant show to win the women's title despite not fielding some of its best players.

On the final day, the Indian men drew with Hungary 2-2, while the women shared the honours with Georgia (2-2).

The Indian men finished with 18 points, two less than the host, which defeated Ukraine 2.5-1.5. Germany, which surprised many, won the bronze after its 2.5-1.5 win over the Nether-



Impressive show: The Indian teams finished among the medals while Praggnanandhaa, Gukesh, Humpy, Divya and Savitha Shri, second right, came up with consistent displays and also took home individual prizes. FIDE

lands. Arjun Erigaisi's win over Peter Leko on the second board proved crucial, as D. Gukesh was beaten by Gleb Dudin. R. Praggnanandhaa and Nihal Sarin drew their games.

Significant win

For the Indian women, Koneru Humpy scored a significant win on the top board against Nana Dzagnidze. Though Divya Deshmukh lost on the second board, to Bela Khotenashvili, Vantika Agrawal and

the magnificent B. Savitha Shri both drew their games to ensure India would end up on the podium, after all.

Slew of board medals

India also retained the Gaprindashvili Trophy, given to the team with the best overall score.

India is the only country to win a medal in both open and women's sections.

India also won a slew of board medals. Savitha struck gold on the reserve

board in the women's section while Divya won the silver on the second board. Humpy and Vantika the bronze on the top and fourth boards respectively. In the open section, Gukesh won the silver on the fourth board, while Praggnanandhaa claimed the bronze on the top board.

Important results (final round): Open:

India drew with Hungary 2-2 (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Richard Rapport; Arjun Erigaisi bt Peter Leko; Nihal Sarin drew with

Benjamin Gledura; D. Gukesh lost to Gleb Dudin).
Uzbekistan bt Ukraine 2.5-1.5; Germany bt Netherlands 2.5-1.5; USA bt Turkiye 3-1; Serbia bt Azerbaijan 2.5-1.5; Armenia bt Croatia 3-1; China bt Uzbekistan (2) 3-1; France bt Denmark 3.5-0.5; England bt Italy 2.5-1.5; Spain bt Georgia 3-1.

The standings: 1. Uzbekistan 20; 2-3. India and Germany 18; 4-7. USA, Azerbaijan, Armenia and Hungary 17; 8-10. China, France and Spain 16.

Women: India drew with Georgia 2-2 (Koneru Humpy bt Nana Dzagnidze; Divya

Deshmukh lost to Bela Khotenashvili; Vantika Agrawal drew with Lela Javakhishvili; B. Savitha Shri drew with Meri Arabidze).

Armenia bt Uzbekistan 3-1; China bt Vietnam 3-1; Kazakhstan drew with Poland 2-2; USA bt Romania 3-1; Mongolia bt Greece 2.5-1.5; France drew with Slovenia 2-2; Bulgaria drew with Latvia 2-2; Indonesia drew with Spain 2-2; Turkiye bt Sri Lanka 3-1.

The standings: 1. China 20; 2. Kazakhstan 18; 3-7. India, USA, Poland, Armenia and Mongolia 17; 8-10. Georgia, Vietnam and Slovenia 16.

Inadequate water, congestion on route mar Wipro Bengaluru Marathon

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

Organisational lapses marred the 13th edition of the Wipro Bengaluru Marathon here on Sunday, with several runners complaining of inadequate water supply and poor crowd management.

Participants said water was unavailable at some stations, while congestion caused by runners from different categories affected the timings.

Organised by NEB Sports, the event attracted around 45,000 participants across four disciplines – Full Marathon, Half Marathon, 10K and 5K.

Ekta Sirohi, who ran the half-marathon, said, "After around the 10-km mark, there was no water available. All the water stations were empty."

Another participant said some well-wishers who



Flaw: An empty water station along the route. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

had gathered along the route came to the runners' aid by purchasing water bottles from nearby shops and distributing them.

There were also complaints about congestion at around the 18km mark, where runners from the Full Marathon and Half Marathon began to merge with those taking part in the 10K and 5K.

"Many of the 5K runners were walking at this stage.

On the other hand, we came in at a good speed and could not get past them," a half-marathon runner said.

NEB Sports CMD Nagaraj Adiga acknowledged the lapses and said the organisers would take the runners' feedback into account.

"In keeping with our green principles, we served water in jars and reusable cups, not bottles.

There was a delay in refilling these jars in one section of the route," Adiga told *The Hindu*.

"We are considering distributing water bottles all along the route from the next edition onwards," he said.

Adiga added that the organisers were considering holding the 10K and 5K events a day before the Full Marathon and Half Marathon in future. This, he said, would help prevent the different categories from merging on the route.

"We want to ensure that every single participant has a good experience. Our team will analyse all feedback and make the necessary improvements," Adiga said.

The results (winners):

Full marathon: Elite men: Bugatha Srinu (02:22:53). **Elite women:** Bhagirathi (03:00:18). **Half marathon: Men:** Ankit Gupta (01:09:12). **Women:** Sugandha Sharma (01:34:55).

SNAPSHOTS



Pure joy: The triumphant Czechia team. REUTERS

Czechia beats Ukraine to win BJK Cup

SHENZHEN: Linda Noskova and Karolina Muchova delivered a first Billie Jean King Cup title since 2018 for Czechia beating Ukraine in the final on Sunday. Noskova sealed the 2-0 victory with a 6-3, 7-6(5) win over world No. 7 Elina Svitolina after Muchova put the Czechs in front with a 6-2, 6-3 win against Anhelina Kalinina.

Turlov becomes second-youngest president of FIDE

SAMARKAND: Timur Turlov was elected FIDE president at the elections held in Samarkand on Saturday.

At 38, Turlov, who is the president of the Kazakhstan Chess Federation, is the second-youngest elected president of FIDE after Kirsan Ilyumzhinov who took office in 1995 aged 33.

Indian women to play two friendlies against Russia next month

KOLKATA: The Indian women's national team will face Russia in two international friendlies in Kolkata on October 8 and 11 during the FIFA women's international match window.

Ethiopia's Guye Adola wins Berlin Marathon

BERLIN: Guye Adola of Ethiopia has won the Berlin Marathon in an unofficial time of 2 hours, 2 minutes and 50 seconds. It's the 35-year-old Adola's second win in the German capital after his victory in 2021.

Gemechu Dida Diriba of Ethiopia was second, 28 seconds behind, followed by Gabriel Gerald Geay of Tanzania.



Adola AP

Isak returns to Liverpool after injury scare

LIVERPOOL: Liverpool striker Alexander Isak has returned to Anfield after suffering a "minor injury" on international duty with Sweden. Isak scored and played the full 90 minutes in Sweden's victory against Romania in the Nations League on Friday. But the 27-year-old will not feature in Sweden's matches against Poland, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and Romania over the remainder of the extended international break.

Mbappe diagnosed with knee hyperextension, says Real

Real Madrid striker Kylian Mbappe sustained an injury related to a hyperextension of his left knee during France's Nations League match against Turkiye on Friday. Mbappe limped off moments after scoring a record-extending 67th goal for his country in the 1-0 victory. France coach Zinedine Zidane said the prognosis was "not good" and on Saturday Real confirmed the result of tests.

"Mbappe has been diagnosed with a hyperextension of the posterior capsule of his left knee," the Spanish giant said. No time frame was given for his expected recovery.

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

There was a moment in the second half of the Asian Games kabaddi gold-medal match against Iran when Aslam Inamdar made a daring raid deep into the opposition half.

His teammate Pawan Sehrawat groaned inwardly as he did so. India's lead was narrow. Iran was still in the contest. It was a risk that could have gone badly wrong. "It was a bad decision," Pawan would say later. But Inamdar made the dash count, securing two touches and emerging unscathed. The points brought India closer to victory. "It was a wrong move, but *ant bhala toh sab bhala* (if the end is good, it's all worth it)," Inamdar said after the match.

He grinned when he recalled the sequence later. It had been a tough decision to make. Wasn't he worried when he made that move? What would have happened if it had gone wrong? "*Bhai*, I've gone through things you wouldn't even imagine. This is nothing," he said.

That, in many ways, is the story of Aslam Inamdar.

There was a time when, as a 14-year-old, he travelled across Maharashtra in search of kabaddi tournaments without even having enough money for a train ticket. He slept under train seats, survived on stale vada pav or whatever food was available at tournaments. He sometimes stuffed leftover food which often spilled into his bag. "If there was work to be done, I did it. I've cleaned toilets. I've sold juice and made tea. I've worked in fields. If there was a kabaddi tournament to play, I found a way to get there."

In Nagoya on Saturday, Inamdar stood on the mat as India beat Iran to win the men's kabaddi gold. It is his second Asian Games gold medal. The distance between those two versions of Inamdar is difficult even for him to comprehend.

"It still feels like a dream to me," he said. "I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals."

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children.

His father passed away when he was young, leaving his mother to raise the family. She worked in other homes, doing household chores and washing utensils, to keep the family going. Later, his elder brother Waseem joined the police force and took responsibility, including helping arrange the marriages of their two sisters.

Money was scarce. Inamdar remembers growing up in a house without proper flooring or roof. There were times when even food was difficult to come by.

So, he learnt early that work meant survival. At 11 or 12, he collected



discarded bottles and sold them to scrap dealers to buy food. Later, he worked at tea stalls and juice bars, washed utensils, cleaned washrooms and worked in farm fields. He admits he stole sometimes. "It was just to fill my stomach. I faced many hard situations without letting them break me," he said.

Through all of it, there was one constant: kabaddi. Waseem was a well-known player across several districts while senior player Rahul Bhor also inspired him. Inamdar wanted to establish his own identity. "No matter how long I worked during the day or night, I always went to the ground to train," the raider said.

Kabaddi was a sport he could afford. It required little equipment, and the village ground was enough. For a boy with very little money, it offered something priceless: a chance. By the time he was 14 or 15, Inamdar was travelling alone to tournaments to compete in the 50kg and 55kg categories. He earned between ₹200

From cleaning rest rooms to winning two Asian Games golds – the rise of Aslam Inamdar

The star raider has cleared many hurdles and come a long way since taking to kabaddi when he was about 14; irrespective of the hardships, the sport has been a constant



and ₹500 a match. The money was little, but it mattered. It bought him meals when he might otherwise have gone hungry. More importantly, it kept him moving from one tournament to the next. The path was neither smooth nor uninterrupted. In 2014, while India competed at the Asian Games, Inamdar was at

home nursing a fractured leg and following kabaddi on television. His life at the time seemed a world away from an international career. "I was just watching kabaddi on TV. But I believe God's plans are always better. My hard work never stopped."

He kept working. Eventually, the Pro Kabaddi League changed the scale of his life.

In his first season, he earned ₹8 lakh. For someone who had once struggled to put food on the table, the money was almost incomprehensible. "Eight lakh felt like eight crore to me," he said.

He did not forget where he had come from. With his first major earnings, he bought a gold necklace for his mother. Kabaddi had given him something that had once seemed almost impossible: financial security, recognition and a career. He went on to captain Puneri Paltan and establish himself as one of India's leading players. Then came the international medals.

Inamdar won his first Asian Games gold in Hangzhou. Three years later in Nagoya, he has another. And once again, the final was against Iran – the one opponent which has consistently pushed India hardest at the Asian Games. "Iran is generally the most challenging opponent for us," Inamdar said. "It has a strong defence and has very experienced players like Fazel Atrachali, who played in his fifth Asian Games."

For Inamdar, beating such a formidable opponent made the gold more meaningful. "A tough challenge makes winning the gold medal feel even more rewarding."

But for Inamdar, the significance of the medal lies beyond the result. It is the culmination of a journey that began when he was a boy travelling across Maharashtra for a few hundred rupees, when he collected scrap bottles for food and worked whatever jobs he could find before heading to the kabaddi ground.

Today, he tries to pass on that experience to younger players. At his training ground in Thane, he speaks to juniors, particularly those from underprivileged backgrounds, about his own journey. He wants them to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up. "I want young, underprivileged players to dream big and aim to achieve even more than I have. I want them to know that whatever happens, they shouldn't stop working hard. They shouldn't stop believing," he said.



It still feels like a dream to me. I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals



Iran is generally the most challenging opponent. It has a strong defence and has experienced players like Fazel Atrachali

THE GIST

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children

He clinched both his gold medals after defeating Iran in finals

The raider wants the next generation to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up

WEST BENGAL

Ballot without the battle

Bypolls for two Assembly constituencies in West Bengal — Nandigram and Rejinagar — scheduled for October 6, are turning out to be an electoral exercise without much contest on the ground. **Shrabana Chatterjee** and **Senjuti Sengupta** report on the dropouts and intimidation that candidates from non-BJP parties are allegedly facing



Congress campaigns door to door without its candidate in Nandigram. SHRABANA CHATTERJEE



In Rejinagar, walls bear the graffiti of Opposition parties, but the BJP is the only party actively campaigning. SENJUTI SENGUPTA

In West Bengal, the Bharatiya Janata Party has the support of 207 MLAs in the 294-member Assembly. Two constituencies are up for bypolls, a situation created because the elected representatives won from other constituencies in the State elections earlier this year. The main parties in the fray are the BJP, the Trinamool Congress, the Congress, and the Left. This is the first election in which former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee’s Trinamool will fight on the symbol of a footballer rather than its flowers-and-grass insignia.

Nandigram: a fight for prestige

The Nandigram Assembly seat, with 17 panchayats, has about 2.5 lakh people, of whom about 27% of the electorate is Muslim. This is Suwendu Adhikari’s home district.

Adhikari has stated several times that the constituency is a prestige fight for him.

The constituency

During the Vietnam War that peaked in the 1960s, West Bengal’s Left Front, powerful in the State then, protested on behalf of the country, with the slogan: “Amar naam, tomar naam, Vietnam, Vietnam (My name, your name, Vietnam, Vietnam).” In 2007, during the movement against forcible land acquisition for a chemical hub, which saw 14 people die, the Left Front government was still in power.

But this time, the same slogan went against it: it became “Amar naam, tomar naam, Nandigram, Nandigram (My name your name, Nandigram, Nandigram).”

Nandigram, a predominantly rural Assembly constituency in coastal Purba Medinipur district of West Bengal, has been synonymous with political change. The fight against forcible land acquisition brought the downfall of the Left Front government in 2011.

In 2021, when Adhikari defeated former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee by a margin of 1,956 votes from Nandigram, the constituency brought to the fore a new leader.

In 2026, he contested and won the seat by a margin of about 9,665 votes. Since he was elected from two constituencies, Nandigram and Bhabanipur, he decided to represent Bhabanipur, where he defeated Banerjee again.

Key candidates

The BJP has fielded Hasirani Rath, the mother of Adhikari’s slain personal assistant.

Hasirani has an emotional appeal because she lost her son in the post-poll violence in West Bengal this year. Her son, Chandranath Rath, was shot dead at point-blank range on May 6, just two days after the BJP came to power in the State for the first time, ending the 15-year-old Mamata Banerjee rule.

“This place has been nurtured by Suwendu Adhikari. Of course he is the only one who will win here,” Hashirani says, after she offered puja at 13 local temples in the constituency as part of her poll campaign in the last week of September.

“Most people in Nandigram have spontaneously accepted me as the daughter of Nandigram, and the mother of their homes,” Hasirani says.

She insists that Adhikari will remain the leader of the people of Nandigram and it is not victory that she is concerned about. “We want the margin of the victory to be 1.5 lakh votes,” she adds.

The Chief Minister had urged the people of Nandigram to ensure the highest-ever margin of victory from the constituency.

Former CM Banerjee initially announced her support to Sanchita Pradhan Dey, who withdrew from the contest. Then she supported the Congress nominee from Nandigram, Milan Pradhan. Within hours, he was arrested in a 19-



We are all Milan Pradhan. He cannot be here because he was wrongfully arrested. We are all standing here as the candidate.

CAMPAIGN MEMBER, Congress party

year-old case. He was a leader and activist who was part of Nandigram’s land movement in 2007. Pradhan has been sent to judicial custody till October 3. His bail plea at the Calcutta High Court was denied on September 22.

“He has always been here at public events, why was he not arrested before? Why arrest him now when he became the Congress candidate?” Arpita, his wife, said in a video message shared by State Congress leaders.

The Left Front has fielded Communist Party of India’s Shanti Gopal Giri for the bypoll.

Key issues and campaign

In the Nandigram bypoll, the Congress is running its campaign on its candidate being arrested by the West Bengal police. “We are all Milan Pradhan. He cannot be here because he was wrongfully arrested. We are all standing here as the candidate,” a campaign member of the Congress said while asking people to vote in the party’s favour.

“Even Mamata didi has asked everyone to support our candidate,” the Congress workers tell people of Nandigram as they go from house to house. The arrest of Pradhan has brought the Congress leadership in West Bengal together and evoked strong response from party’s high command. Leader of Opposition in Parliament, Rahul Gandhi, called it “political revenge, the murder of democracy”.

“The BJP has no faith in fair elections – that’s why it wants to cling to power, sometimes through vote theft, sometimes through stealing governments, and sometimes through stealing parties,” Gandhi said on X.

Meanwhile, the BJP is driving its by-poll campaign on the emotional appeal of a mother who has lost her child. Adhikari accompanied Hasirani when she filed her nomination papers.

Addressing a gathering after the nomination, the Chief Minister exuded confidence by saying that the BJP will win by “such a big margin in Nandigram that no one has ever imagined”. He said that Chandranath Rath’s biggest sin was that he was his aide.

He promised to fulfil all the promises made to the people of Nandigram.

What the electorate says

Purnima, 50, from Gopalchak area in Nandigram is emotional about the mother’s loss. “A mother lost her child in these politics. We are bound to vote for her,” she says.

Amina Bibi, 65, from the Mohammadpur area says that people of Nandigram have always spoken truth to power and she does not shy away from speaking the truth now.

“I fought shoulder to shoulder with Suwendu during the Nandigram protests. But since he became CM, he has not dared to come back here because he knows he has not done anything for us,” she says. A man in his mid-50 from Mohammadpur in Nandigram who did not want to be named, says, “This is not a democracy where there is no fair election and people are not allowed to participate. In a democracy every candidate should get a fair chance to campaign and contest. That is missing here.”

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Rejinagar: wall graffiti speaks

Rejinagar constituency has over 2.56 Lakh voters and about 69% of the electorate in the constituency are Muslim voters. The Bhagirathi river, a distributary of Ganga, passes through the constituency, which spans over two blocks: Beldanga I and II, comprising nearly 14 panchayats. A predominantly rural constituency, the region has little employment opportunities and youth migrate for work.

The constituency

Rejinagar is located less than 15 kilometres from Plassey, where a war between the East India Company and Nawab Siraj-u-Daulah of Murshidabad almost 270 years changed the history of the subcontinent forever.

The constituency, located in West Bengal’s Murshidabad district, was a highlight of the 2026 Assembly poll. Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP) leader Humayun Kabir’s had attempted to construct a mosque styled on the lines of the Babri masjid in Ayodhya.

Kabir’s campaign in the 2026 Assembly poll on the issue of construction of the mosque, split the Muslim votes, polarised Hindus, and eventually was one of the reasons that led to fall of the 15-year-old Trinamool Congress government.

Kabir, who was expelled from the Trinamool Congress, set up AJUP and won elections from Naoda and Rejinagar in the district. He vacated Rejinagar where his margin of victory was over 58,000 votes. The project of construction of the Babri-style mosque next to a national highway has been stalled and the site that had hundreds of people thronging before the Assembly polls, is desolate. The constituency had witnessed violent protests during the anti-CAA [Citizenship (Amendment) Act] protests in 2019. In 2024, there was an explosion during a Ram Navami procession, which left about 20 people injured.

Key candidates

The by-polls at Rejinagar have been necessitated after Humayun Kabir resigned from his Rejinagar seat on June 4. The AJUP chairperson has fielded his son Golam Nabi Azad. Neither is campaigning in a big way, saying there is intimidation by the administration, controlled by the ruling party.

The Banerjee-backed faction of the Trinamool Congress has fielded Rabiul Alam Chowdhury, a former MLA, as their candidate. Chowdhury had represented the seat for three terms, first being elected from the Congress in 2011, and later as a Trinamool Congress nominee. Chowdhury too had said he would withdraw from the contest, but later decided to reconsider after intervention from Banerjee.

The Congress has fielded Abdullahil Kafi, the Leader of the Opposition from the Murshidabad Zila Parishad. The Ritabrata Banerjee-led TMC faction (Democratic TMC) has fielded Safiuzzaman S.K. and CPI(M) has fielded Saeed Asad Ali. The BJP is hoping for a split in minority votes and that a polarisation of Hindu votes will make way for its victory.It has fielded Shankharavh Sarkar.

Key issues and campaign

The leaders of the AJUP and Banerjee-backed Trinamool Congress have alleged intimidation

by the police and said that they are not being allowed to contest. Kabir has decided to stay away from the campaigning, accusing the local police of slapping fake cases against his workers and arresting them.

According to Kabir, “Fifteen of my workers have been arrested by the police, while many have fled to other places fearing the police’s constant threats. This is terrifying. Police are picking up everyone they see with me. They have become the BJP’s agents. I can’t risk my workers’ lives,” he says.

The MLA was also called for questioning to Berhampore Police Station on September 21 and 23, in relation to a viral audio clip that pointed to subject matter pertaining to communal tension.

Kabir adds that his son is still visiting some areas, “But we stopped major campaigning. I will communicate with people and campaign for my son through Facebook only,” he says.

On September 19, West Bengal police arrested Saiful Islam, an independent candidate from Rejinagar, who has close associations with the AJUP leadership. While graffiti of the Opposition candidates can be seen all across the constituency, the only candidate who is actively campaigning is the BJP’s Sarkar.

While the party offices of the candidates in Opposition wear a desolate look, the party office of the BJP at Rejinagar is bustling with activity.

“TMC has not done anything for this area in the last 15 years. Humayun Kabir’s corruption has also been exposed. He duped people of crores in the name of his Babri Masjid replica project. The public is not foolish. They want a change,” Sarkar says. The BJP candidate says that he is fighting this election on a development pitch and getting good response from people across communities.

While Sarkar is campaigning across the constituency, the graffiti of Opposition candidates – the hammer and sickle of CPI(M), hand of Congress, football player of Mamata’s All India Trinamool Congress, and whistle of AJUP – are on the walls of Rejinagar.

What the electorate says

Mohsin Sheikh, who resides near Beldanga Police Station in Rejinagar, says, “The election looks very different this time. There is not much show of parties and their candidates, unlike previous elections. A strange silence has captured the area.” There are voters who lament the lack of development in the region, health facilities, and transport. “The nearest hospital in our area is five-six kilometres away. Those who stay in the part of the constituency which is connected to the national highway may still get proper transport to reach there in emergency cases. But what about the people from the other side of the river?” says Nafisa Bibi, who runs a teashop at Saktipur village, which is around 12 kilometres from the ferry-ghat.

Hamid, a street vendor, stops at the boundary of the under-construction mosque. “It was a good initiative. When it’s completed, everybody will come to pray here from even the neighbouring districts. Our business will grow,” he says, as he prepares his jhaalmuri mix.

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A southern port to development



CM YK A IN-X